

The Noble Mahāyāna Sūtra: Gathering of Buddhas

Āryabuddhasaṃgītināmamahāyānasūtra · Toh 228 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་སངས་རྒྱལ་བའི་ཞུ་བ་བྱ་བའི་ཐག་པ་ཆེ་པའི་མདོ།

The Noble Discourse on the Harmonious Gathering of Buddhas, known in Sanskrit as the Ārya Buddhasaṃgīti Nāma Mahāyāna Sūtra and in Tibetan as Pakpa Sangyé Drowa Zhéjawa Tekpa Chenpo'i Do, is a Mahāyāna sūtra set during a time of five great worldly degenerations, in which the Buddha addresses a vast assembly of monks, bodhisattvas, and gods gathered at a mountain cave near a mango grove in the Middle Country. The text takes its name from the theme of a harmonious gathering or concert of buddhas, and its opening situates this teaching amid the challenges of a degenerate age, suggesting a concern with how beings may find guidance and refuge when the world has declined. It is Toh 228 in the Kangyur, classified among the Mahāyāna sūtras.

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear. At one time the Blessed One was dwelling in the Middle Country, in a cave of the crag of the lord of excellent mountains Vaideha, in the vicinity of the dense mango grove of the Middle Country. He was together with a great Saṅgha of five thousand monks, and with twenty-five thousand bodhisattvas — all of them irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening — together with the bodhisattvas Mañjuśrī, Maitreya, and others. Also present together with them were eighty-four thousand sons of the gods, every one of them dwelling in the vehicle of the bodhisattva.

Now at that time five degenerations arose in the world: the degeneration of lifespan, the degeneration of sentient beings, the degeneration of the age, the degeneration of afflictions, and the degeneration of views. On account of these, the four assemblies did not come eagerly to the presence of the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha in order to hear the Dharma. And even when they did come, they did not act in accordance with the Dharma; they showed no reverence even toward the Tathāgata. Sentient beings, wearied by the teaching of the Dharma, sat distracted and were scattered by all manner of diversions.

Then the Blessed One reflected thus: How pitiable — these sentient beings are utterly weary; they do not take the teaching of the Dharma to heart. They do not come in order to hear the Dharma or to behold the Tathāgata, and even

when they do come to hear the Dharma, they do not act accordingly and do not fix their minds upon it as the word of the Buddha. I shall thoroughly quench the thirst of all people by establishing them inwardly and in the proper way. And in other buddha-fields as well, I shall consult with other blessed buddhas on the Dharma-discourse called the Assembly of Buddhas.

Now at that time, in those other buddha-fields too, the four assemblies of those other blessed buddhas had likewise become utterly weary and ceased coming to hear the Dharma, and those blessed buddhas were also quenching the thirst of their four assemblies by dwelling in the manner of establishing them inwardly and in the proper way, each within his own buddha-field.

Now at that time, beyond eighty-four thousand buddha-fields to the east, in a world-system called Universally Radiant, there dwelt a Tathāgata, Arhat, perfectly and completely awakened Buddha named King of Resolute Craving, who was living and dwelling and teaching the Dharma even then. Those blessed buddhas gathered there for the purpose of consulting in the assembly of the Tathāgata, and there was not one among those blessed buddhas who had not yet conferred or who did not engage in consultation — the Tathāgatas consulted together for the purpose of teaching the Dharma and taming sentient beings.

Then the Blessed One reflected: Where will those blessed buddhas gather? And from that reflection this thought arose: Those blessed buddhas will gather to the east. Beyond eighty-four thousand buddha-fields there is a world-system called Universally Radiant, and there dwells a Tathāgata, Arhat, perfectly and completely awakened Buddha named King of Resolute Craving, living and teaching the Dharma. There those blessed buddhas will gather.

Then the Blessed One spoke to the Venerable Ānanda: "Ānanda, the Tathāgata will now enter into the cave of Indraśāila. Once he has entered, he will remain in inner meditative composure for three months. Therefore, Ānanda, during those three months you must not send any gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas (dri za, scent-eaters), asuras, kinnaras (mi 'am ci, half-humans), great serpents (mahoragas), humans, or any others whatsoever to the cave of Indraśāila."

When this was declared, the Venerable Ānanda addressed the Blessed One thus: "Blessed One, I am unable to restrain gods of great power with subtle bodies. Blessed One, I do not possess miraculous power and magical ability such as the Elder Maudgalyāyana possesses. Blessed One, please command

him for this task."

Then the Blessed One replied: "I am capable of guarding." When Ānanda said this, the Blessed One spoke to him as follows: "Ānanda, enough. Do not speak thus to the Tathāgata. The Tathāgata has no need to be guarded by anyone — no need whatsoever. There is nothing that need be protected in the Tathāgata, for he is the Victor over all foes. Throughout this world of beings — with its gods, māras, brahmin ascetics, and wandering renunciants — I see no one, not even the slightest, who is capable of disturbing or moving so much as the hem of the Tathāgata's robe, having been blessed by the Tathāgata's blessing. Ānanda, you need trouble yourself little. The Tathāgata himself will bestow his blessing.

"Moreover, Ānanda, when the Tathāgata has entered into inner meditative composure, should monks, nuns, laymen, laywomen, gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas (nam mkha' lding, sky-soaring eagles), kinnaras, great serpents, humans, and non-humans come to his presence, Ānanda, you should teach them the Dharma in these words:

'Friends, obtaining a human birth is rare. Dwelling in a conducive place is rare. The arising of a Tathāgata is rare. Faith in the Dharma and Vinaya taught by the Tathāgata is also rare. The state of a monk who has gone forth and received full ordination is rare. A spiritual friend is rare. A person who abides in earnest effort is rare. One who has confidence in and aspiration for emptiness is also rare. A monk who teaches the Dharma in complete purity is rare. One who possesses a mind of giving is rare. One who receives is rare. One who, having received, cultivates the perfection of generosity is also rare. Those sentient beings who appreciate what has been done for them and who feel what has been done — they too are rare. Those sentient beings who desire training and do not abandon it even for the sake of their lives — they too are rare. Those sentient beings who, having generated compassion and loving care for all sentient beings, arouse the awakening mind for unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening — they too are rare. And rarer still are those sentient beings who, having just aroused the awakening mind, strive earnestly to purify it without delay.'

"Ānanda, when the Tathāgata has entered into inner meditative composure, teach the Dharma in this way. And if the fourfold assembly of monks, nuns, laymen, and laywomen, together with gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kinnaras, great serpents, humans, and non-humans arrive

and come, teach them the Dharma in those same words. And furthermore, Ānanda, teach the Dharma in this way as well:"

The Tathāgata has declared wrong views to be deeply blameworthy in many ways; therefore you must not hold wrong views. What then is wrong view? It is this: not being liberated, not being tamed inwardly, not being at peace, not being disciplined, not being thoroughly disciplined — and yet paying homage with joined palms to various gods; placing faith in various forms of ethical observance and various kinds of patience, in rivers, ponds, reservoirs, water hollows, mountains, wild animals, birds, and trees; being possessed of attachment, aversion, and delusion; and making images of such things — to regard all of these and the like as true is called wrong view.

Furthermore, Ānanda, what is wrong view? Clinging to the notion of a self — that is called wrong view. Clinging to the notion of a sentient being, grasping at a life-force, clinging to the notion of a person, clinging to the notion of annihilation, clinging to the notion of permanence — all of these are called wrong view.

Ānanda, in brief, the most subtle forms of wrong view have now been taught. Ānanda, whether a son of good family or a daughter of good family — even one who is still young yet aspires to pass into nirvāṇa — if such a perception arises in them, that too is called wrong view.

Ānanda, furthermore, when the Tathāgata enters into inner meditative composure, teach the Dharma in this way. Make the Dharma your need. Dwell in delight and satisfaction and joy in the Dharma. Purify your livelihood completely. Aspire to the trainings. Be full of faith, and cultivate great clarity. Maintain a sense of shame, together with respect and reverence. Let your mind be alert. Intend to emerge from all three realms. Apply diligence to cultivating loving-kindness, compassion, joy, and equanimity. Maintain patience and speak kind words. Rely on the meaning, not on the words. Rely on gnosis, not on consciousness. Rely on the definitive sūtras, not on the provisional ones. Rely on the nature of reality, not on the person. Through proper mental application, realize the three gateways of liberation. Make emptiness your domain. Having thoroughly abandoned the grasping at a self, and being free from the domain of signs, thoroughly relinquish all signs, and make the gateway of liberation of signlessness your domain. And go beyond aspiration altogether.

Ānanda, teach the Dharma to sentient beings by setting forth dependent origination. The teaching called dependent origination means that no phenomenon whatsoever arises without conditions. You should therefore penetrate dependent origination to its core. Ānanda, what is it to correctly realize dependent origination as it truly is? Dependent origination is non-arising. And how does one realize it? It is patience with non-arising — and not becoming conceited even about that. That is the correct realization of dependent origination as it truly is.

Ānanda, you should teach the Dharma to sentient beings by setting forth the distinctions of the noble truths. Ānanda, what are the distinctions of the noble truths? Ānanda, listen to what the noble truth is. Ānanda, the noble truth is neither true nor false. That which is neither true nor false — that is called the noble truth. How many distinctions does this truth have? The truth of non-arising, the truth of being just as it is, the truth of being free from attachment, the truth of cessation,

the truth of passing into nirvāṇa, the truth of complete liberation, the truth of the absence of things, the truth of being free from conceptual elaboration, the truth of not moving, the truth of spontaneous accomplishment, the truth of not taking up, the truth of not casting away, the truth of not being made, the truth of not making, the truth of not falling, and the truth of having no abiding place. Ānanda, whatever phenomenon does not arise, does not diminish, does not abide, and does not change into something else — that is called the truth. Ānanda, with that in mind, the Tathāgatas teach the Dharma by saying that noble persons are produced by the unconditioned. Knowing that suffering does not arise — this is the noble truth of suffering, and that is the realization of suffering. Knowing the origin fully as that which does not move while being the cause — this is the realization of the origin of suffering. The complete exhaustion of all phenomena that are subject to thorough cessation, their utter non-arising — this is the cessation of suffering. As for the path therein: the path that does not make into two, that enters into the single mode of the virtuous and the non-virtuous, and that realizes the single mode of all phenomena — that is called the path.

Ānanda, the three gateways of liberation are also called the path. By that path, the fully and perfectly awakened buddhas of former times, together with their Śrāvaka Saṅghas, passed on excellently into nirvāṇa. Ānanda, this is called the noble eightfold path, namely: right view, right thought, right speech, right action, right livelihood, right effort, right mindfulness, and right meditative

absorption. This is a teaching of equanimity, and because of that equanimity, since one does not engage in conceptual thought regarding any phenomenon whatsoever, one is therefore said to have entered the path.

Ānanda, furthermore, teach the Dharma in this way as well: strive in the practice of yoga that establishes mindfulness. Realize the true mode of the thirty-seven factors conducive to awakening and become skilled in guiding beings — teach the Dharma in those very words. Ānanda, as for realizing the true mode of the thirty-seven factors conducive to awakening and being skilled in guiding beings: it is the intrinsic nature of syllables and the equanimity of speech. Ānanda, the Tathāgata sets forth phenomena by means of syllables, yet those syllables are themselves empty by nature, neither arising nor ceasing, so whether spoken they are only that much, and whether unspoken they are only that much — they neither increase nor diminish. Therefore those syllables are not syllables. Ānanda, a monk who knows the equanimity of syllables and the equanimity of speech should be recognized as one who has realized the true mode of the factors conducive to awakening and is skilled in guiding beings.

Ānanda, furthermore, when the Tathāgata has entered into the inner state of correct placement, and the four assemblies that have come approach him, Ānanda, you should teach them the Dharma beginning from the equanimity of the three times. Ānanda, what is the equanimity of the three times? Ānanda, the past time is that which has not been born. The future time is that which has not been seen. The present does not abide. All phenomena abide in error and are naturally at peace. Even emptiness has no time at which it abides: the past is empty, the future is empty, the present too is empty. Just as time is empty, so too is suchness like that. Just as time is empty, so too are sentient beings empty. Ānanda, it is like this: the absence of plurality and the entering into a single mode — that is the equanimity of the three times.

Ānanda, speak further on the Dharma for the sake of fully knowing the three realms. How is the full knowledge of the three realms to be understood? Ānanda, a yogin engaged in the practice of yoga reflects in this way: the desire realm arises from conceptual fabrication; the form realm and the formless realm likewise arise from conceptual fabrication. Since whatever is conceptually fabricated is devoid of real existence, one realizes that all three realms are without inherent nature, and therefore does not engage in conceptual thought, does not engage in discursive thought, does not take up, does not cast away, does not desire, does not aspire, does not feel pride, and

does not mentally intend. Freed from all mental intention in this way, one actualizes, with little effort, the three gateways to liberation: emptiness, signlessness, and wishlessness.

Ānanda, what is the actualizing of the three gateways to liberation? It is the undisturbed evenness of equanimity, not constructing any phenomenon whatsoever, not fashioning anything at all. Knowing that all phenomena have been exhausted from the very beginning, one does not even give rise to mental engagement accompanied by gnosis, does not make them into one, and does not make them into many. This, Ānanda, is the equanimity of actualizing the three gateways to liberation.

Ānanda, speak further on the Dharma for the sake of your fully knowing the five aggregates. Ānanda, how is the full knowledge of the five aggregates to be understood? Ānanda, yogins engaged in the practice of yoga, dwelling in solitary and secluded places, train themselves in this way. The Tathāgata also declared:

Form is like a mass of foam.

Feeling is like a water bubble.

Perception is like a mirage.

Formations are like a plantain trunk.

Consciousness is like an illusion.

Thus did the Kinsman of the Sun declare. The yogins engaged in the practice of yoga train themselves thus: those similes taught by the Tathāgata are true, they are exactly so, and not otherwise. Foam is empty, not belonging to the desire realm, not belonging to the form realm, not belonging to the formless realm. That which does not belong to the three realms is undesignatable and cannot be designated. Nor can a self or a sentient being be designated in foam, for in it no self or sentient being is observed — it is absent. Why is this? Because all phenomena are without self. Feeling, perception, and formations are likewise the same. As for what is declared, "consciousness is like an illusion" — an illusion is empty, not belonging to the desire realm, not belonging to the form realm, not belonging to the formless realm. That which does not belong to the three realms is undesignatable and cannot be designated. Nor can a self or a sentient being be designated in an illusion, for in it there is no self or sentient being, and none is to be observed. Ānanda, understanding the aggregates in this way — knowing that all phenomena are without self — that is the full knowledge of the aggregates.

Ānanda, speak further on the Dharma for the sake of fully knowing and abandoning the six inner and outer sense bases. How are the six inner and outer sense bases to be fully known? Ānanda, the eye is empty of self and of what belongs to self, and by its very intrinsic nature it is suchness. Likewise, the ear, the nose, the tongue, the body, and the mind are each empty of self and of what belongs to self, and by their very intrinsic nature they are suchness. Form is empty of self and of what belongs to self, and by its very intrinsic nature it is suchness. Likewise, sound, smell, taste, touch, and mental phenomena are all empty of self and of what belongs to self — and so too by their very intrinsic nature they are suchness. Thus has the Tathāgata declared. Ānanda, in that which is empty by intrinsic nature, no phenomenon whatsoever can be designated. In it there is no eye, no ear, no nose, no tongue, no body, no mind, no form, no sound —

no smell, no taste, no touch, no mental phenomena.

Ānanda, the gnosis that does not rely upon anything external with respect to those phenomena — that is the thorough understanding of the six inner and outer sense bases. And what is the abandonment of the six inner and outer sense bases? It is this: not grasping at any phenomenon, not being conceited about any phenomenon, not moving toward signs — that is the abandonment of the six inner and outer sense bases.

Therefore, Ānanda, if monks, nuns, laymen, laywomen — the fourfold assembly — along with gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas (dri za), kinnaras (mi 'am ci), great serpents (mahoragas), humans, and non-humans should come to you, you should teach them the Dharma in these very words. And at that moment, the Blessed One blessed them with just such a blessing: those who were fit vessels for this teaching of the Dharma heard it, while for the rest it did not even reach their ears, and they saw the Tathāgata saying nothing at all.

When the Teacher had taught this, five hundred monks attained complete liberation of mind from all the defilements. Forty-two thousand sons of the gods obtained the pure, stainless Dharma-eye with respect to phenomena. Three thousand nuns attained complete liberation of mind from all the defilements. And seven hundred billion living beings gained freedom from attachment.

Then the Blessed One, having taught the venerable Ānanda in this way, spoke to him: "Ānanda, arise. Go to the cave of Indraśaila and spread a grass seat for

the Tathāgata. The Tathāgata will sit upon that grass seat and dwell there for three months, remaining inwardly in perfect meditative composure."

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, the venerable Ānanda replied: "Blessed One, I shall spread the seat. But what kind of seat does the Blessed One require?"

The Blessed One said: "Ānanda, enough — do not speak so. Former Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas were also pleased with grass seats. Ānanda, the Tathāgata's ease does not come from comfort of material requisites; the Tathāgata's ease comes from the ease of abiding in the Dharma."

Then the venerable Ānanda, in accordance with the Blessed One's word, rose from his seat and departed from the Tathāgata's retinue to fetch grass.

At that moment, innumerable tens of billions of millions of sons of the gods placed in the hands of the venerable Ānanda divine grass, soft to the touch, resembling kāśikā cloth. The venerable Ānanda took that grass, went to where the cave of Indraśaila was, entered into it, and spread the grass seat for the Blessed One.

The very moment the venerable Ānanda had spread the Blessed One's grass seat, those same innumerable tens of billions of millions of sons of the gods laid divine garments upon the grass seat. So many were those garments that they filled all of Jambudvīpa, covering it densely — and yet by the miraculous blessing of the Blessed One, all those many garments became merely four finger-widths in height.

Then the Blessed One rose from his seat and proceeded to the cave of Indraśaila. As he went, all the musical instruments sounded without being played, and showers of flowers rained down, those showers of flowers filling this great trichiliocosm. Then the Blessed One entered the cave of Indraśaila, sat in cross-legged posture, straightened his body upright, and abided with mindfulness fully established.

Then, at that time, the Blessed One manifested a miracle in the cave of Indraśaila, causing it to appear as if fashioned from vaiḍūrya.

Then, at that time, the sentient beings throughout this great trichiliocosm who were to be tamed by a buddha, and whose roots of virtue had fully ripened, beheld the Tathāgata seated in the cave of Indraśaila in this manner: just as a face is reflected in a perfectly clear mirror, so did those sentient beings behold

the Tathāgata.

Then, at that time, the Blessed One sent forth hundreds of thousands of rays of light from the palm of his right hand, and those rays illuminated this great trichiliocosm, so that the sun and moon became visible to the eyes of sentient beings.

Then, at that time, all sentient beings were free from the harm of attachment, free from aversion, free from delusion, free from pride, free from concealment and remorse, free from envy, free from avarice, free from anger, free from malice, and free from the intention to harm. At that time all sentient beings were possessed of minds of loving-kindness and came to regard one another as father and mother.

Then the Blessed One entered into meditative absorption in the samādhi called "Abiding without Location, Spontaneously Present, Bearing the Character of Space, Moving without Signs."

No sooner had the Blessed One entered into that samādhi than this great trichiliocosm shook in six ways.

Then all the sentient beings dwelling in this great trichiliocosm beheld the Tathāgata's conduct, his miraculous display of supernatural power, and the transformations of his samādhi. Upon seeing this, forty-two thousand divine sons aroused the mind of unsurpassed perfect and complete awakening. At that moment, all of them took divine flowers — mandārava blossoms — and scattered them toward the cave of Indraśaila and toward the Blessed One. As soon as they had scattered those flowers, they circumambulated the cave of Indraśaila seven times and then vanished from sight.

Then, at that time, the Blessed One fashioned an emanation in the cave of Indraśaila and left it there, while the Blessed One himself — king of the desire realm — departed for the buddha-field of the Tathāgata called Sarvaprabhāsa, the world-realm of Sarvaprabhāsa.

Then, at that time, in all the buddha-fields in the ten directions, as numerous as the grains of sand in the Ganges River, Tathāgatas equal in number to the grains of sand in the Ganges appeared in the world during this age of five degenerations. The buddha-fields of those Blessed Ones are extremely base — just as the world-realm of Endurance of the present Blessed One Śākyamuni is as it is, so likewise are the buddha-fields of those buddhas, those Blessed Ones, extremely base. In the same way, the sentient beings there are

dominated by attachment, dominated by aversion, dominated by delusion; they are disrespectful, ungrateful, deceitful, treacherous, and inclined toward the inferior. The sentient beings dwelling in those world-realms of those buddhas, those Blessed Ones, have no real wish to see them, make no effort to seek the Dharma, do not regard the teaching of the Dharma as necessary, and though they have ears they do not listen. Thus those Tathāgatas, through skillful means, turned inward and entered into perfect equipoise.

Other emanations were sent forth, and they went to every buddha-field of the Tathāgata, the Blessed One Jugsé Gyalpo, to the world-realm called Pervaded by Light, in order to teach and expound the category of Dharma called "The Buddha's Discussion." For that reason it is called "The Buddha's Discussion."

The buddhas, the Blessed Ones, do nothing whatsoever except, for the sake of future generations, to carry out the Buddha's Discussion. Seeing that after a Tathāgata has passed fully into nirvāṇa, sentient beings who desire the Dharma will inevitably arise, and that those buddhas, those Blessed Ones, those lords of the Dharma, will themselves engage in the discussion of Dharma, the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, reflected: "Why then should we ourselves not discuss the Dharma?" With that intention in view, the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, engaged in the Buddha's Discussion.

At that time, in that world-realm called Pervaded by Light, immeasurable and incalculable buddhas, Blessed Ones, assembled. Why is that world-realm called Pervaded by Light? In that buddha-field, even the names of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas are not heard; that buddha-field is filled exclusively with bodhisattvas. Those bodhisattvas themselves emit light from their own bodies, their bodies are of a golden hue, they are endowed with perfectly complete major marks of various kinds, and since the light of those bodhisattvas pervades everywhere, the world-realm is therefore called Pervaded by Light.

Now, what is the Buddha's Discussion? It is the exact and genuine understanding of the manner in which all phenomena are. What then are all phenomena? What is the manner? What is the understanding?

All phenomena are one single phenomenon, and that phenomenon cannot be expressed by anyone as being either Dharma or non-Dharma. Why is that? Because they are unborn and unarisen. Though they are expressed by the word "dharma," the six inner sense bases, the six outer sense bases, the aggregates, and the elements — all these are called "all phenomena," and all of them are nothing more than verbal designations.

For one who, without any fabrication with respect to all phenomena, understands things exactly as they are, there are no aggregates, no elements, no sense bases, no permanence, no annihilation — and thus no middle position either. This is what is called the sameness of all phenomena. In just this way, one speaks of all phenomena by the name "empty of intrinsic nature." Yet even that name involves no fabrication; it is expressed by a name. And even that name lacks intrinsic existence. That is what is called the Buddha's Discussion.

What is the manner? The manner is this: the manner of being without attachment, the manner of non-arising, the manner of seclusion, the manner of being as things actually are, the manner of suchness, the manner of the dharmadhātu, and the manner of the ultimate limit. The statement "all phenomena are empty" — this is the genuine manner.

All phenomena do not arise, do not stir, have no activity, do not come, do not go, have nothing that is theirs, have no owner, have nothing to be grasped, and have no reference point. Because they are utterly exhausted, they are exhausted. Because they are unborn, they are inexhaustible. Because they are truly secluded, they are of a nature that is peace. Because they are free of any abode, they have no abode. Because they are free of any manner, they have no manner. Because they have no arising, they have no falling. They are liberated. They are neither gathered nor dispersible. Because they are described as unborn, they are equal to non-arising. Because they are unlike any comparison, they are without equal.

Whatever is entered through a letter — that is the way. All phenomena are free of names. They have not gone, have not come, have not been obtained, have not been lost, have not been carried away, have not been taken up. They are described as neither equal nor unequal. They have not been seen, have not been heard, are not remembered, are not cognized. They are not grasped, not firmly grasped. They are not joyful, not aversive. They are not peaceful, not made peaceful. They are not scattered, not unscattered. They are not coarse, not subtle. They are not long, not short. They have no middle, no end, no beginning. They have no disintegration, no limit. They have no pleasure, no pain. They have no knower, no movement. They have no abandonment, no taking up. They have no touching, no showing, no intending, no cognizing. They have no arrogance, no mental engagement, no proliferation. They are to be expressed as having no abandonment and no non-abandonment. They have no guarding and no non-guarding. What is not hidden has no hiddenness.

In them there is no obtaining and no coming to obtain. In them there is no thing and no absence of thing. There is no meditating and no non-meditating. There is no annihilation and no permanence. In them there is no gaining and no losing. They are not past, not future, not present. They are not knowing and not non-knowing. They are not consciousness and not non-consciousness. They have no sound, no path of speech, no expression, no voice, no speaking, no letter, no entering through a letter, no entry, no loss. They are not far, not near. They have no obtaining and no non-obtaining. In them there is no engagement of mind, no self, no sentient being, no life force, no person. They have no possession of moral discipline and no poor conduct. They have no possession of patience and no practice of impatience. They have no diligence and no laziness. They belong to no one and pertain to no one. They are not anything whatsoever and not the absence of anything whatsoever. They are not liberation and not bondage. They are not space and not the absence of space. They are like mere names — not to be taken up, not taken up, not born, not dying. They have no taming and no non-taming, no activity and no non-activity. They have no vow and no transgression, no harm from transgression. They have no wavering and no non-wavering, no thought, no conceptual thought, no discursive thought. They have no taking and no discarding, no birth and no death, no giving and no receiving, no distraction and no peace, no having been made peaceful. They have no nature of reality and nothing opposed to the nature of reality. They have no dust and no freedom from dust. They have no sounding, no causing to sound, no coming to sound. They have no attachment, no aversion, no delusion, no clinging, no anger. They have no hither shore, no farther shore, no middle, no expanse, no limit. They have no liberation and no liberator. They have no going and no staying, no hoping and no turning back. They have no arising and no disintegration, no cutting and no breaking, no joining and no connecting, no binding and no freeing, no grasping and no non-grasping. They have no light and no non-light, no life force and no sustaining, no person and no sentient being. They have no designation and no absence of designation. They have nothing to be expressed and nothing not to be expressed. This is called entry through the letter. A bodhisattva, a great being, who is endowed with this entry does not become attached to names. Being unattached, one enters into the phenomena of non-attachment. One comes to enter into abiding in the way. This is called the way, and it is also what buddhas deliberate upon.

Now, what is steadiness in this? All phenomena abide because they abide in the dharmadhātu, the basic space of phenomena. Entry into the nature of reality in this — that is called steadiness. Now, what is that nature of reality?

The nature of reality is this: it is the absence of conceit regarding phenomena. When there is no conceit, there is no arrogance. When there is no arrogance, there is no conceptual thought, and there is no thorough conceptualization. When there is no thorough conceptualization, all that is called conceptuality neither does much nor does little, neither takes up nor abandons. It does not think about or conceptualize the past. Neither does it do so regarding the future, nor regarding the present. What does not abide in the present is not seen as truly following along — and that is the very equality of the three times. In that, there is no arising, no deterioration, no abiding, and no transformation into something else. That is called the dharmadhātu, the basic space of phenomena. With that in mind, it has been said: whether a Tathāgata appears or does not appear, the nature of reality, the dharmadhātu, the very stability of phenomena, the faultlessness of phenomena — that is stability itself.

Why is it called the faultlessness of phenomena? Whatever is without fault is faultlessness, and therefore it is called the faultlessness of phenomena. Now, what are the faults? Reifying things as self is a fault. Reifying things as mine is a fault. Viewing things as causes, perceiving things as name-and-form, perceiving all phenomena as things, stopping and engaging, and the conceit of attachment — these are faults. The conceit of pride, of fabrication, of intention, of conceptual thought, of self-aggrandizement — grasping at aggregates, grasping at causes, grasping at sense bases, and thinking "I will abandon the three realms," thinking "I will exhaust attachment, aversion, and delusion," thinking "I will cultivate the path," thinking "I will actualize the gates of liberation," thinking "I will actualize the fruit of stream-entry," thinking "I will actualize the fruit of once-returning and of non-returning," thinking "I will actualize arhathood" — such conceptualization is a fault. These are the faults of dwelling in the vehicle of the hearers.

Thinking "I will cultivate the four foundations of mindfulness," thinking "I will cultivate the four genuine restraints, the four bases of miraculous power, the five faculties, the five powers, the seven branches of awakening, and the noble eightfold path" — that is a fault. Thinking "I must realize the Four Noble Truths," thinking "I must exhaust these afflictions," thinking "I must cultivate these phenomena" — these are the faults of dwelling in the vehicle of the hearers.

Now, what are the faults of dwelling in the vehicle of the bodhisattva? Thinking "I will become a buddha" is a fault. Thinking "I will attain awakening" is a fault. Thinking "I will give generosity" is a fault. Thinking "I will cut through miserliness" is a fault. Thinking "I will perfectly purify my ethical conduct and abandon bad conduct and bad character" is a fault. Thinking "I will be endowed with ethical discipline" is a fault. Thinking "I will abide in patience" is a fault. Thinking "I will abandon the wrongs of harmful intent and contempt" is a fault. Thinking "I will cultivate patience" is a fault. Thinking "I will abide in the practice of diligence, abandon the stain of laziness, and take up diligence" is a fault. Thinking "I abide in meditative concentration, I cultivate meditative absorption, I have entered meditative equipoise" is a fault. Thinking "I will arise from it" is a fault. Thinking "I will attain meditative concentration" is a fault. Thinking "I will cultivate the Perfection of Wisdom" —

— is a fault. Thinking "I will train in the Perfection of Wisdom and thereby become a buddha" is a fault. Thinking "Through the Perfection of Wisdom I will be drawn forth and, by the nirvāṇa of a buddha, pass completely into nirvāṇa" is a fault. Thinking "I will perfectly accomplish the primordial wisdom of a buddha" is a fault. Thinking "I will train in the trainings of a buddha" is a fault. Thinking "I will perfectly complete the ten powers of the Tathāgata" is a fault. Thinking "I will perfectly complete the eighteen unshared qualities of a buddha" is a fault. Thinking "I will attain the powers, the faculties, the fearlessnesses, and the individual perfect knowledges" is a fault. Thinking "I will accomplish eloquence" is a fault — for a bodhisattva, to whatever extent there is meditation, conceptual thought, aspiration, grasping, or abandoning, to that very extent there is fault. Every characteristic mark is a fault. Every conceptual thought is a fault. Every engagement is a fault. Now, because those phenomena are absent, one therefore speaks of "being without fault." That which is without fault is the nature of reality itself, and therefore phenomena are said to be "without fault." This too is called the deliberation of a buddha.

Furthermore, the deliberation of a buddha is this: accomplishing the first arising of mind by a bodhisattva. And what is meant by accomplishing the first arising of mind by a bodhisattva? It is this: accomplishing non-arising. Why so? Because all sentient beings are without mind. That which is without mind is non-arising — that is to say, the patient acceptance of phenomena as unborn: this is the first arising of mind. Furthermore, the first arising of mind by a bodhisattva is the donning of firm armor. And what is the donning of firm

armor? It is this: a bodhisattva should arouse a mind like a vajra. And what is the arousing of a mind like a vajra? These ten are the arousing of the vajra-like mind of a bodhisattva. What are the ten? They are: the armor of taking up measureless saṃsāra; the complete relinquishment of all possessions; the evenness of mind toward all sentient beings; the resolve that "I myself will lead all sentient beings to complete nirvāṇa through the nirvāṇa of a buddha, yet even when all sentient beings have been led to complete nirvāṇa, no sentient being whatsoever will have passed into nirvāṇa"; knowing all phenomena to be unborn while not relinquishing diligence; possessing the aspirational prayer of wisdom acting for the benefit of all sentient beings; perfectly accomplishing the primordial wisdom of omniscience; realizing that all modes are one; not regarding pleasure and displeasure; and having abandoned attachment and anger. These are called the arousing of the vajra-like mind of a bodhisattva. Furthermore, accomplishing the first arising of mind by a bodhisattva is this: not generating any perception of the three realms, yet also not falling into the failure to generate perception.

Furthermore, the deliberation of a buddha is this: the supreme distinction among the six perfections. And what is the supreme distinction among the six perfections? Within the Perfection of Generosity there is a worldly kind and there is a transcendent kind. In the same way, up through the Perfection of Wisdom, there is a worldly kind and there is a transcendent kind. Now, what is the Perfection of Generosity that is worldly and not transcendent? It is thus: when a bodhisattva gives, the master of the gift is a śramaṇa (a renunciant) or —

— a brahmin, a pauper, a destitute person, or a beggar, and he gives to them: to those who desire food, food; to those who desire drink, drink; to those who desire a vehicle, a vehicle; to those who desire clothing, clothing — and likewise gold, jewels, pearls, beryl, conch, crystal, coral, silver, fine rice, a wife, sons, daughters, up to and including an entire kingdom — giving all of this completely to those who desire it. And in doing so, he sets his eyes on nothing external, on no possession other than his own body, and he gives everything away completely, abiding in that complete giving. Then he thinks: "I am the giver. This one is the recipient. I am giving a gift — I am free of miserliness. I am the master of giving. I am relinquishing all my possessions. I am doing as the buddhas have instructed. I am practicing the Perfection of Generosity." With such thoughts he gives while focusing on all sentient beings as his object, and after giving, he dedicates that gift of his on behalf of all sentient beings

with the aspiration: "May all sentient beings come to happiness through this gift of mine." He dedicates the gift to all sentient beings.

This is attachment in three forms — and what are the three? The perception of a self, the perception of another, and the perception of giving. This is called the worldly Perfection of Generosity; it is not transcendent. Why is it called "worldly"? Because it does not transcend worldly action — therefore it is called "worldly."

Now, what is the Perfection of Generosity that is transcendent and not worldly? It is this: the complete purification of the three spheres. And what is the complete purification of the three spheres? Here, when a bodhisattva gives, he does not apprehend a self, he does not look upon a recipient, he does not take delight in or aspire toward the karmic ripening of that gift, and he does not see the gift itself as something substantial. This is the complete purification of the three spheres.

Moreover, when a bodhisattva gives, he dedicates fully to all sentient beings, and yet he does not apprehend those sentient beings as sentient beings either; he dedicates to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening, and he does not perceive even a single atom of a phenomenon there. This is called the transcendent Perfection of Generosity. Why? Because in this way it transcends the worldly. And what is "the worldly"? It is the five appropriated aggregates. And what transcends them? That which possesses equanimity, is free of conceit, is free of attachment, and is free of abiding — this transcends them.

In the same way, ethical discipline that abides is worldly; non-abiding is transcendent. Likewise, patience, diligence, meditative concentration, and wisdom — that which abides is worldly; that which does not abide is transcendent.

Furthermore, knowledge of all worldly activities — alphabetic letters, sign language, enumeration, calculation, mantra, and traditional learning — this is called worldly wisdom. And that wisdom which is transcendent is inexpressible and beyond designation.

In this way, the six perfections have their supreme distinctions — and this too is a buddha's deliberation.

When the Blessed One set forth this teaching in the buddha-field of the Tathāgata, the king Yugaṣṭri, seventy times ten million bodhisattvas gave rise

to acceptance of the non-arising of phenomena (Skt. anutpattikadharmakṣānti). The great trichiliocosm, that world-system, trembled in six ways.

And further, this deliberation of a buddha is this: the bodhisattvas leaping from ground to ground.

What then is the leaping from ground to ground? It is this: all phenomena are without transition, and all phenomena are without transition and without destruction. With respect to these grounds, there is no pride of conceit, no conceptual intention, and though there is no purifying of the grounds, there is also no correct subsequent seeing of the grounds.

What then is the purifying of the grounds? A bodhisattva dwelling on the first bodhisattva ground should carry out ten purifications. What are these ten? The purification of elevated aspiration; the purification of beneficial things; the purification of an even mind toward all sentient beings; the purification of relying upon a spiritual friend (Skt. kalyāṇamitra); the purification of thoroughly seeking the Dharma; the purification of the arising of successive buddha-fields; the purification of longing for the body of a buddha; the purification of expounding the Dharma as a gift without any material reward; the purification of overcoming the swelling of pride; and the purification of truthful speech. These ten purifications are what a bodhisattva dwelling on the first bodhisattva ground should undertake.

A bodhisattva dwelling on the second bodhisattva ground should keep in mind, and apply diligent effort to, eight further qualities that arise in successive buddha-fields. What are these eight? They are: perfect purity of moral discipline; repaying kindness and knowing what kindness has been received; abiding in the power of patience; cultivating the experience of joy and delight; never abandoning any sentient being; being unstained in great compassion; showing reverence to one's teacher and regarding that teacher as the Instructor; and seeking with diligence the perfections. These eight qualities are what a bodhisattva dwelling on the second bodhisattva ground should keep ever in mind and train in.

Furthermore, a bodhisattva dwelling on the third bodhisattva ground should abide in five qualities. What are these five? They are: being insatiable in the matter of great learning; expounding the Dharma as a gift without material reward; dedicating the roots of virtue toward the complete purification of buddha-fields; not growing weary in the face of immeasurable cycles of

samsāra; and abiding in a sense of shame and moral scrupulousness. These five qualities are what a bodhisattva dwelling on the third bodhisattva ground should thoroughly cultivate and perfect.

A bodhisattva dwelling on the fourth bodhisattva ground should not abandon ten qualities. What are these ten? They are: dwelling in solitude; having few desires; knowing contentment; not abandoning the qualities acquired through training; not abandoning the trainings; abiding on the ground of taming; disparaging the qualities of sensual desire; sustaining the mind of awakening even when beset by weariness; not letting the mind shrink even when giving away all one's possessions; and not looking upon any thing with attachment. These ten qualities are what a bodhisattva dwelling on the fourth bodhisattva ground should never abandon.

A bodhisattva dwelling on the fifth bodhisattva ground should completely abandon twelve qualities. What are these twelve? They are: associating with householders; associating with fully ordained nuns; attachment to one's own clan; a miserly mind; gathering in places of congregation; a mind of ill-will; quarreling; disparagement; distraction; contentiousness; praising oneself and belittling others; abandoning the ten paths of non-virtuous action; abandoning great arrogance and conceit; abandoning what is inverted; abandoning doubt; and being tolerant toward attachment, aversion, and delusion. These twelve qualities are what a bodhisattva dwelling on the fifth bodhisattva ground should thoroughly abandon.

Furthermore, a bodhisattva dwelling on the sixth bodhisattva ground should perfectly complete six qualities. What are the six? They are the six perfections. Furthermore, there are six qualities such a bodhisattva should not engage in. What are the six? One should not give rise to the mind of a śrāvaka. One should not give rise to the mind of a pratyekabuddha. One should not give rise to a mind of weariness. On seeing one who is begging, one should not give rise to a mind of timidity. Having given something away, one should not become discontented. One should not give rise to a mind of ill-will toward sentient beings. These are the six qualities one should not engage in.

Furthermore, a bodhisattva dwelling on the seventh bodhisattva ground should not engage in twenty qualities. What are the twenty? They are as follows: grasping at a self; grasping at sentient beings; grasping at a life-force; grasping at a person; grasping at annihilation; grasping at permanence; the perception of signs; a view that posits causes; attachment to name and form;

attachment to the aggregates; attachment to the elements; attachment to the sense bases; attachment to the three realms; clinging to the three realms; abiding in the three realms; attachment to the view that abides in the Buddha; attachment to the view that abides in the Dharma; attachment to the view that abides in the Saṅgha; attachment to the view that abides in moral discipline; and being frightened by the thought that phenomena are empty. These twenty qualities are what a bodhisattva should not engage in.

Furthermore, that bodhisattva should perfectly complete twenty qualities. What are the twenty? They are as follows: realizing emptiness; manifesting signlessness; knowing wishlessness; thoroughly purifying the three spheres of action; being tenderhearted and compassionate toward all sentient beings; not disparaging those sentient beings; seeing all phenomena as equal in nature; realizing the authentic mode; attaining the patience of non-arising phenomena; demonstrating a single mode of conduct; vanquishing conceptual thought; turning back perception; turning back the afflictions; calm abiding; the ground of insight; taming the mind; pacifying the mind; knowing wishlessness; not being attached to those who are dear; and having an even, balanced mind toward all sentient beings. These twenty should be perfectly completed.

Furthermore, a bodhisattva dwelling on the eighth bodhisattva ground should engage in four qualities. What are the four? Cultivating an even mind toward all sentient beings; performing miraculous transformations through direct knowledge; displaying buddha-fields, which perfects one's view of them; and rendering service to the buddhas while contemplating the form body of a buddha. A bodhisattva should engage in these four qualities.

Furthermore, a bodhisattva should engage in four more qualities. What are the four? Knowing those whose faculties are excellent and those whose faculties are not excellent; thoroughly purifying buddha-fields; entering again and again into the meditative absorption that is like an illusion, absorbing evenly in that state; and, in whatever way sentient beings come to have faith, emanating one's body accordingly and intentionally taking rebirth in existence. A bodhisattva dwelling on the eighth bodhisattva ground should perfectly complete these four qualities.

Furthermore, a bodhisattva dwelling on the ninth bodhisattva ground should become skilled in aspirational prayers, and should accomplish aspiration prayers in accordance with what one has aspired to. One should know the

languages of gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, humans, and non-humans, and display eloquence in them. One should be endowed with an excellent birth from the womb; be endowed with an excellent clan; be endowed with an excellent upbringing; be endowed with an excellent lineage; be endowed with excellent attendants; be endowed with excellent longevity; and

be endowed with an excellent birth; be endowed with an excellent array at the tree of awakening; and fully perfect every accumulation of qualities.

Furthermore, a bodhisattva dwelling on the tenth bodhisattva ground is to be described as a Tathāgata himself. The advancement from ground to ground among bodhisattvas is called the buddha-domain of the perfectly and completely awakened Blessed Ones.

The second fascicle. Furthermore, the buddha-domain is as follows: the equality of letters, the equality of sounds, and entry through the gateways of the aspects of letters. What is entry through the gateways of the aspects of letters? The gateway of A is because all phenomena are unborn and no sense base is apprehended. The gateway of RA is because all phenomena are free from dust. The gateway of PA is because all phenomena are taught in the ultimate sense. The gateway of CA is because all phenomena are free from death, transmigration, and birth. The gateway of NA is because all phenomena are free from names and have not obtained and have not lost the intrinsic nature of a name. The gateway of LA is because all phenomena transcend the world and because the causes and conditions of the tentacle of craving are destroyed. The gateway of DA is because all phenomena are tamed and, having been tamed, are completely cut off. The gateway of BA is because, through utter solitude, all phenomena are free from bondage. The gateway of RA is because all phenomena — form and the rest — are emptiness. The gateway of SA is because, through the non-apprehension of attachment in all phenomena, there is no attachment and no liberation. The gateway of VA is because all phenomena have completely cut off the pathway of speech. The gateway of TA is because all phenomena are unmoved from suchness. The gateway of YA is because all phenomena are as they truly are. The gateway of STA is because all phenomena have no arrogance, no attachment, and no aversion. The gateway of KA is because in all phenomena there is no agent. The gateway of SA is because all phenomena do not turn back from equality. The gateway of MA is because all phenomena are free from defilement, utterly without stain, free from fault, free from turbidity. The gateway of GA is because, through the non-apprehension of the apprehended and the

non-apprehended in all phenomena, they are profound, like the surface of the sky, utterly solitary. The gateway of STHA is because all phenomena are free from dryness and free from moisture, and have neither a near shore nor a far shore. The gateway of JA is because birth, aging, and death are not apprehended in all phenomena. The gateway of ŚHVA is because all phenomena are free from breath, inhalation, exhalation, inward-going breath, and outward-going breath. The gateway of DHĀ is because all phenomena abide in the dharmadhātu, the basic space of phenomena. The gateway of ŚA is because all phenomena have become calm abiding, are tamed, and have reached the place of peace. The gateway of KHA is because, having no root and no ground, all phenomena are like space. The gateway of KṢA is because all phenomena are utterly exhausted, do not turn back from exhaustion, and through being unmoved remain still and unshaken. The gateway of JA is because, gnosis not moving in all phenomena, they are unknown, unrecognized, not mentally engaged with, and unseen. The gateway of A is because all phenomena are beyond the conventions of what is and what is not, and are therefore neither possessed nor separated from, neither universally possessed nor universally separated. The gateway of BHA is because all phenomena are free from burden. The gateway of CHA is because all phenomena have no color whatsoever — that is to say, they are empty. The gateway of SMA is because, on account of bewilderment in all phenomena, one should not say mindfulness, nor should one say confusion. The gateway of SVA is because all phenomena are empty of intrinsic nature and empty of sound. The gateway of BHA is because all phenomena are empty of sound. The gateway of SA is because all phenomena are forever exhausted, utterly cut off, and permanence is thoroughly severed.

The gateway of GHA is because all phenomena have no perceivable density — there is no piling up, no scattering. The gateway of E is because all phenomena are solitary, and so they abide in a thoroughly non-abiding manner. The gateway of NA is because atoms are not perceived in any phenomenon — therefore all phenomena do not go, do not come, do not stand, do not sit, do not lie down, and are free from conceptual thought. The gateway of SVA is because all phenomena are free from pervasion: there is nothing that pervades, nothing by which pervading is done, and nothing in which pervading occurs — the unpervasive is like space. The gateway of SKA is because the aggregates are not perceived in any phenomenon. The gateway of DZVA is because all phenomena are free from epidemic disease — there is

no contagion, no illness. The gateway of STYA is because all phenomena are relinquished in thorough relinquishment. The gateway of BA is because the path is cut off in all phenomena, and so they utterly pass beyond sorrow, resembling the state of one who has passed beyond sorrow. The gateway of HA is because all phenomena dwell at the extreme, and so there is no death and transmigration, no birth. And this is how it is: beyond HA there is no syllable. In this there is no name, no intrinsic nature of any kind — it cannot be spoken, cannot be expressed, cannot be shown, cannot be written, cannot be read. Just as that is unmade, so should one understand all phenomena.

This entrance into dhāraṇī is the entrance by way of the teaching beginning with the syllable A and so forth. Abiding in that entrance, a bodhisattva will come to know mastery in all syllables, will come to unite with the equality of all phenomena, and will attain knowledge of speech. Whatever bodhisattva of good understanding hears, takes up, holds, reads, or teaches to others this mudrā of the gateway of entering through syllables — the teaching of the gateway of E — should be understood to possess these twenty qualities. And what are the twenty? He will be endowed with mindfulness; endowed with clear understanding; endowed with intelligence; endowed with discernment; endowed with eloquence; he will attain dhāraṇī with little effort; he will become free from doubt and free from hesitation; upon hearing pleasant words from others he will not give rise to a mind of attachment, and upon hearing harsh words from others he will not give rise to a mind of aversion, and he will neither become inflated nor bent in submission; he will be victorious over enemies; he will be skilled in speech; skilled in the aggregates, skilled in the elements, skilled in the sense sources; skilled in causes; skilled in conditions; skilled in the dharmadhātu; skilled in sharp and dull faculties; skilled in knowing the minds of others; skilled in teaching the Dharma; skilled in the gnosis of what is possible and what is not; skilled in skillful means; skilled in coming and going, and skilled in conduct; and he will also attain skill in conscience and consideration.

Should any woman who has aroused the mind of unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening hear this entrance — this mudrā of the gateway of the way of syllables, the teaching of A — take it up, hold it, read it, and teach it extensively to others, immediately upon hearing it she will attain ten qualities. And what are the ten? They are as follows: this will be her last birth in a woman's body; she will completely abandon the states of non-leisure; she will attain leisure and opportunity; upon seeing a buddha arise she will have faith;

having faith she will pay reverence; the Tathāgata, knowing her intention, will teach her the Dharma; having heard that Dharma she will attain patient acceptance; she will become irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening — and that too is the buddha's gift.

Furthermore, the buddha's gift is as follows: understanding the manner in which the equality of a buddha — with the three spheres perfectly pure — does not arise; teaching the Dharma exactly as it is; fully knowing the three realms; fully knowing the natures of attachment, aversion, and delusion; and not falling into nihilism —

not permanent, not abiding, not going; entering into the single mode of the three vehicles, understanding the single mode; not debating all phenomena, not disputing; unequal, equal to the unequal; not coming, not going, not moving; without characteristic mark; no phenomenon of the buddhas having been perfectly and completely awakened to, not known; buddhas not apprehending wisdom or non-wisdom; afflictions not abandoned, purity not actualized; not attained, not to be actualized, not meditated upon, not realized; not apprehended by the buddhas, not destroyed; buddhas not apprehending a buddha arising; not the Dharma, not the Saṅgha; sentient beings neither liberated nor bound by the buddhas — this too is the buddha's gift.

Why is this so? Because all phenomena are primordially pure. The buddhas have not seen, heard, thought about, or known any phenomenon whatsoever — therefore the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, do not speak, do not teach, and will never expound. Buddhas are neither endowed with wisdom nor not endowed with it; they are not a field of offerings, nor are they not a field of offerings — and they do not engage in purifying generosity. Buddhas do not act, do not engage fully in activity. Buddhas have no body whatsoever. Buddhas are not beheld as form, are not a phenomenon, are not a characteristic mark, and are not the dharmadhātu. Buddhas have not arisen; they have not ceased; they have neither passed into nirvāṇa nor not passed into nirvāṇa; and they will not come to attain complete nirvāṇa. Why is this so? Because all phenomena are primordially and completely beyond sorrow. Buddhas are not solitary, nor have they entered into the midst of the many. Buddhas are not seen, not heard, not honored by anyone, and will not be honored. Buddhas do not establish any phenomenon as either one or many. Buddhas have not attained awakening. Buddhas do not bestow acquisition. Buddhas do not turn the wheel of Dharma — just as the name "buddhas" is, so

it is; and the first limit and the final limit of sound are likewise the same. This is equality, and in that which is equality, there is nothing whatsoever that is unequal. In that where there is no inequality, there is no nectar whatsoever. Where there is no nectar at all, no medicine arises — this is the topic of the buddhas. The example is given in order to guide sentient beings; buddhas do not debate, do not dispute, and do not establish anything through debate.

When the Blessed One, King Juktsé (Skt. Jugiṣṭyārāja), the Tathāgata, taught this enumeration of Dharma-categories on the theme of the buddhas in the buddha field known as the world-system Kundu Öd (Skt. Sarvaprakāśa) — "Utterly Radiant in All Directions" — twenty-two thousand bodhisattvas attained patient acceptance of the unborn nature of phenomena. And those bodhisattvas, though present with those many billions of buddhas, did not see any other Tathāgata — they saw solely the Tathāgata King Juktsé.

Then Mañjuśrī in his youthful form, dwelling in this very world-system of Endurance, had this thought: "Today, in the eastern direction, in the buddha field known as the world-system Kundu Öd — 'Utterly Radiant in All Directions' — of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata King Juktsé, buddhas and Blessed Ones as numerous as the grains of sand in the river Gaṅgā have gathered from every direction in the ten quarters, and are engaged in debating and expounding this enumeration of Dharma-categories on the theme of the buddhas."

"I shall go in order to pay homage to those Blessed One buddhas and to hear the Dharma they teach. If one would travel and roam through the ten directions in order to behold those Blessed One buddhas and to hear the Dharma, then how much more readily should one go when, with so little trouble, all have assembled in a single buddha field — I shall certainly go. It is rare, I think, to hear of or to behold such great beings appearing in the world."

Then Mañjuśrī in his youthful form said to the bodhisattva Maitreya: "Maitreya, let us now go to the buddha field of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata King Juktsé. Many billions of buddhas are assembled there at this very moment, expounding the enumeration of Dharma-categories on the theme of the buddhas. Let us hear the Dharma from them. Let us behold those Tathāgatas. And why is this? It is rare to see those great beings — those great elephants among men — assembled in one place."

When he had spoken thus, the bodhisattva Maitreya said to Mañjuśrī in his youthful form: "Mañjuśrī, you go. I shall not come. And why is this? The

Blessed One buddhas are not easy to please, and that assembly would not open any opportunity for the likes of us to behold or to hear them. Moreover, Mañjuśrī, one does not behold the Tathāgatas through their form body. The Tathāgatas are the dharmakāya, the truth body; and that nature of reality — dharmatā itself — is something that no one has ever seen, heard, or venerated."

Mañjuśrī said: "Maitreya, have you not venerated the Tathāgata?"

Maitreya replied: "Mañjuśrī, I do not venerate the Tathāgata. And why is this? No one is able to venerate the Tathāgata. And why is this? The Tathāgata and suchness are not two."

Mañjuśrī said: "Maitreya, to what does the expression 'non-dual' apply?"

Maitreya replied: "Mañjuśrī, 'non-dual' means that the afflictions are neither identical nor distinct. Mañjuśrī, 'non-dual' means that which is free of two aspects. And what does 'free of two aspects' mean? If one knows in this way — 'this is defilement, this is purification' — that constitutes two aspects. If one conceives — 'this one possesses moral discipline, this one has bad conduct' — that makes two aspects. If one conceptualizes — 'this is a śrāvaka, this is a pratyekabuddha, this is a fully and perfectly awakened buddha' — that makes two. If one conceptualizes — 'these are to be cultivated, these are to be abandoned, these are to be directly realized' — that makes two aspects. If one mentally frames — 'this is to be known by primordial wisdom, this is to be known by consciousness' — that makes two aspects. Mañjuśrī, any conceptual thought of consciousness that enters into duality — down to the slightest thought of 'this is a buddha' — all of that makes two aspects. Mañjuśrī, were I to speak on non-duality for an eon or for the remainder of an eon, even then it would never be exhausted — for my eloquence, however consummate, would reach its end before the topic did. And why is this? Because I see neither extremes nor a middle. Mañjuśrī, 'non-dual' is this: all phenomena are of one mode, undifferentiated, neither identical nor distinct."

He then said: "Maitreya, you have realized the non-arising of all phenomena. Mañjuśrī, as for me —

You who say 'were I to speak on non-duality for the remainder of an eon, my eloquence would never be exhausted' — that very act of speaking is itself a great object of focus.

Maitreya then said: "Mañjuśrī, do not become attached to letters. All letters are without motion from the defining mark of non-arising."

Then Mañjuśrī, the youthful, said to all those bodhisattvas: "Sons of good family, come this way. Let us go to the buddha-field of the Tathāgata King of Confident Engagement to behold those Tathāgatas and to hear the Dharma they teach."

Thereupon the bodhisattva called Heap of Confidence said to Mañjuśrī, the youthful: "Mañjuśrī, since no one is capable of beholding the Tathāgatas, why do you say 'come this way, let us go to behold the Tathāgatas'? Which Tathāgatas are to be beheld? Mañjuśrī, Tathāgatas are neither past, nor yet to come, nor present. Any phenomenon empty in the three times cannot be beheld — that is what has been said."

Mañjuśrī replied: "Then to behold the Tathāgata — with what eye-consciousness should one behold him? Should one behold him with a flesh eye, or with a divine eye? If one beholds with the flesh eye, the flesh eye is empty, and what is empty cannot see. If one beholds with the divine eye, then examining that as a divine eye, one forms the perception 'this is a divine eye' — and with an eye that is an object of examination, one cannot behold the Tathāgata."

He continued: "Son of good family, you who point to emptiness — by that very approach, no one will behold the Tathāgata, no one will venerate him. Son of good family, all the utterances one might express — even so much as the syllables 'Tathāgata,' 'buddha,' 'sentient being,' 'wanderer,' 'veneration,' 'beholding' — all those syllables uttered and spoken are empty by the very nature of syllables. Therefore the word 'equality' does not disturb suchness, nor does it reverse suchness. Those among you who are able, come; those who are not, stay — I myself will go."

Then Mañjuśrī, the youthful, insatiable for Dharma and non-dual, departed alone, and by the power of the buddhas, not a single member of that assembly departed.

Then, in the time it takes a mighty man to stretch out his arm or draw it back — in just such a single instant, a mere moment — Mañjuśrī, the youthful, vanished from the Endurance world-system and appeared in the Realm of Total Light.

Then Mañjuśrī, the youthful, circumambulated the great trichiliocosm seven times, and bowing his head at the feet of those blessed buddha Bhagavāns, sat down to one side.

Now at that time, to the right of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata King of Confident Engagement, there sat a nun named Dispeller of Doubt, cross-legged, who had entered into and remained in the meditative absorption called Appearing as Immaculate Moonlight.

Then the Blessed One, the Tathāgata King of Confident Engagement, thought to himself: "This Mañjuśrī, the youthful, has been praised by the blessed buddhas as one who endures the profound, who dwells in emptiness. He has come here from the Endurance world-system, moved by a great object of focus and possessed of a strong sense of self —

"By my hurling him to the summit of the encircling mountain range, and by his then proceeding to teach the profound Dharma, it will be made manifest to people of later generations and to bodhisattvas of the future. And why is this? Because the Dharma of the buddhas is so inconceivably profound that even one who is supreme in dwelling in emptiness — someone like Mañjuśrī the youthful — will be hurled to the summit of the encircling mountain range."

Then the Blessed One, the Tathāgata King of Confident Engagement, said this to Mañjuśrī the youthful: "Mañjuśrī, what object did you not perceive that brought you here?"

Mañjuśrī replied: "Blessed One, while I was in that world-system of Endurance, this thought arose in me: 'Blessed buddhas appearing in the world are rare. Even hearing the Dharma is rare. Yet in the world-system called Pervading Light, innumerable and uncountable blessed buddhas from the ten directions have assembled. Having assembled, they expound a category of Dharma called Discussion of the Buddhas. I wish to behold those Tathāgatas and to hear them teach the Dharma.' With that thought, Blessed One, I have come to this buddha-field in order to hear the Dharma."

Then the Blessed One, the Tathāgata King of Confident Engagement, swiftly marshaling and bringing to bear a display of miraculous power by which Mañjuśrī the youthful was to be hurled to the summit of the encircling mountain range — and hurled in such a way that he would not know where he was being taken or carried — marshaled and brought to bear that display of miraculous power: the power of swift lifting and hurling.

Then Mañjuśrī the youthful, having been hurled to the summit of the encircling mountain range, reflected and this thought arose in him: "By what cause and what condition have I been hurled from the midst of that great and splendid assembly of the Buddha — so beautiful, so lovely, filled with great elephants of that kind — to this summit of the encircling mountain range? Who has hurled me to the summit of the encircling mountain range?" And as he was thinking in that way, this further thought arose: "It is the Blessed One, the Tathāgata King of Confident Engagement, who has hurled me to the summit of the encircling mountain range."

Then Mañjuśrī the youthful thought: "I was hurled from that assembly. Yet the sister Dispeller of Doubt sits cross-legged in the presence of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata King of Confident Engagement, and she was not hurled. Why is it that she was not hurled while I was? It must be that this sister has roots of virtue blazing intensely and has become supremely patient with regard to the profound, whereas I am perhaps not of that kind."

Then Mañjuśrī the youthful thought: "Let me arouse the power of miraculous ability and return to that assembly." And so Mañjuśrī the youthful marshaled and brought to bear such a display of miraculous power that in a single arising of mind he could traverse buddha-fields surpassing in number the grains of sand of the Ganges River from the eastern direction — and yet, even bringing that display of miraculous power to bear, he was unable to travel even a fraction the size of the tip of a hair in that direction, let alone return to the assembly. There was simply no such possibility.

Then Mañjuśrī the youthful traversed all the world-systems of the ten directions, infinite and boundless — and yet, such was the power and blessing of the Buddha, he was unable to return to that assembly.

Then Mañjuśrī the youthful, having traversed countless hundreds of thousands of tens of millions of buddha-fields in the ten directions, came to rest once more upon the summit of the surrounding mountain range, and this thought arose in him: "The blessing of the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, is supremely powerful. I am unable to overcome it through any display of my miraculous powers. Yet in this there is no fault on the part of the buddhas, the Blessed Ones. Why is that? It is because the Tathāgatas have no concealment from a master in the Dharma. It is simply that I myself am only a little diminished, and therefore I have been unable to go to where he teaches the Dharma of peace. The Tathāgatas have no concealment from a master in the Dharma. Rather, it

is because the Tathāgatas are equal toward all sentient beings that I, abiding in the establishment of mindfulness, take this very summit of the surrounding mountain range to be my abiding place."

Now the mindfulness established by Mañjuśrī the youthful was this: that all phenomena are without mindfulness, without mental engagement; that all phenomena are non-abiding; that all phenomena are without a place of abiding. Why are they non-abiding? Because there is no going. No phenomenon whatsoever truly and ultimately exists, and therefore they do not go. That which does not go does not abide. This showing of both abiding and non-abiding, together with the absence of mindfulness and mental engagement — this is the establishment of mindfulness of Mañjuśrī.

Then, from Mañjuśrī the youthful's abiding in that establishment of mindfulness, forty-two thousand divine sons went to where Mañjuśrī the youthful was, bowed at his feet, and stood to one side.

Then a divine son named Raśmīdhvaja — Banner of Light-Rays — came to that assembly, sat down, and spoke these words to Mañjuśrī the youthful: "Mañjuśrī, in what abiding do you abide, that you have now risen?"

Mañjuśrī replied: "Divine son, if there were an abiding in me, then by abiding I would be made to abide. But, divine son, since all phenomena are empty, there is no abiding in me whatsoever. Yet, divine son, you ask: 'In what abiding do you abide, that you have now risen?' I abide by abiding in the establishment of mindfulness, and thus I have now risen."

The divine son asked: "Mañjuśrī, what is it like to abide in the establishment of mindfulness?"

Mañjuśrī replied: "It is to be without mindfulness of all phenomena and without mental engagement with them."

The divine son asked: "Mañjuśrī, is it by abiding there, where there is no mindfulness and no mental engagement, that you have now risen?"

Mañjuśrī replied: "Whatever abiding is one in which all ordinary persons — being like children — are made to wander through attachment, aversion, and delusion: it is by abiding in that abiding that I have now risen."

The divine son Raśmīdhvaja then asked: "Mañjuśrī, what is the abiding that a buddha does not perceive?"

Mañjuśrī replied: "Divine son, abiding in emptiness — this is what a buddha does not perceive. Abiding in signlessness, and abiding in wishlessness — these are what a buddha does not perceive. Therefore, it is by abiding in that abiding that I have now risen."

The divine son asked: "What is it like to abide in the establishment of mindfulness?"

Mañjuśrī replied: "Divine son, where there is no mindfulness and no mental engagement — that is the supreme abiding. Those who abide in that abiding do not abide in the desire realm, do not abide in the form realm, and do not abide in the formless realm. Those who do not abide in the three realms abide in the abiding of equanimity. For those who abide in the abiding of equanimity, there is nothing that is unequal. For those in whom there is nothing unequal, there is no going."

Those for whom there is no going do not see ignorance. Those who do not see ignorance — in them, knowing has not arisen. Those in whom knowing has not arisen do not arise. Those who do not arise will not come to be. Those who will not come to be have no disintegration. Those who have no disintegration do not arise. Those who have not arisen cannot be differentiated. Those who cannot be differentiated, divine son, are supremely pure. Divine son, that noble abiding is free from dust.

The divine son asked: "Mañjuśrī, what is meant by dust?"

Mañjuśrī replied: "Divine son, the consciousness that arises apprehending a buddha as an object — that is dust. Divine son, a characteristic mark is dust. Perception, grasping, attachment, conceit, bowing down, pride, paying homage, desirous thought, anger, apprehending an object, going, aspiration, conceptual thought, the mark of conceptual thought, thorough conceptual thought, discursive thought, pervasive conceptual thought, mental engagement with objects, arousing the sense of self, holding to nihilism, holding to eternalism, holding to non-existence, holding to wrong views, holding to existence, holding to non-existence — divine son, whatever extent of discursive thought and conceptual elaboration, mental engagement, intention, and deliberation there is, all of that is called dust in the noble Dharma-discipline."

Then the divine son Victorious Banner of Light Rays said to Mañjuśrī the youthful, "Excellent!" and spoke thus: "Mañjuśrī, excellent, most excellent! It is most excellent that you have explained this abiding in the establishment of

mindfulness."

Mañjuśrī said: "Divine son, please do not think of it as sufficient. You confer excellence through a Dharma that is unborn, unarisen, and undisplayed. Divine son, this firm establishment of mindfulness cannot be spoken of or expressed. Why? Because all phenomena are inexpressible. All phenomena are inexpressible — why? Because in them there is nothing whatsoever to express; therefore they are not expressed."

The divine son Victorious Banner of Light Rays then asked: "Mañjuśrī, if one abides in that abiding concerning which you said 'I have now risen, having abided in the abiding in which all the attachment, aversion, and delusion of all ordinary beings who are like children flow' — if one abides in that, will the attachment, aversion, and delusion of all ordinary beings who are like children flow?"

Mañjuśrī replied: "Divine son, if all ordinary beings who are like children abide in the absence of things, their attachment, aversion, and delusion will flow. If all ordinary beings who are like children abide in the dharmadhātu, abide in the ultimate limit, abide in suchness — their attachment, aversion, and delusion will flow. Why? Because no phenomenon whatsoever can be described as separate from the dharmadhātu, from suchness, and from the ultimate limit."

The divine son asked: "Mañjuśrī, what is the meaning of the word 'ultimate limit'?"

Mañjuśrī replied: "Divine son, 'ultimate limit' is a synonym for 'the limit of sentient beings.'"

The divine son asked: "Mañjuśrī, what is the meaning of the word 'the limit of sentient beings'?"

Mañjuśrī replied: "It is a synonym for 'the limit of self.'"

The divine son asked: "Mañjuśrī, what is the meaning of the word 'the limit of self'?"

Mañjuśrī replied: "It is a synonym for 'the limit of saṃsāra.'"

The divine son asked: "Mañjuśrī, what is the meaning of the word 'the limit of saṃsāra'?"

Mañjuśrī replied: "It is a synonym for 'space.' Divine son, it is like this —

just as the expanse of space has no limit, no interruption, no length, no shortness, no roundness, no squareness, no fineness, no coarseness, no flatness, no whiteness, no blackness, no redness — other than that, space is counted merely as a name, the name 'space,' and even that name is a conventional designation. In just the same way, divine son, all phenomena have the nature of the limit of space, the movement of space, the name of space. Divine son, consider this: space neither arises, nor ages, nor dies, nor comes into being, nor is afflicted, nor is purified, is without attachment, without aversion, is neither honored nor dishonored. It is by its limitlessness, in the manner of the uncountable, that all phenomena are to be counted. Divine son, because they are beyond designation, all phenomena cannot be shown to be either gathered or dispersed, and they cannot be established as such. Divine son, all phenomena are unexamined, untamed, and not holy. Divine son, this is the equality of all phenomena — not an inequality — this is suchness, unerring suchness.

When the Teacher taught this, all those divine sons gave rise to acceptance of the unarisen nature of phenomena (anutpattikadharmakṣānti). Having gained that acceptance of the unborn nature of phenomena, out of reverence for the Dharma they scattered divine mandāra flowers upon Mañjuśrī, the youthful one. The moment those flowers were scattered, by the blessing of the youthful Mañjuśrī they came to rest suspended in the sky above, abiding there without any fixed location, neither drawn in nor gathered together.

Then the youthful Mañjuśrī said to the divine son Raśmirājadhvaja: "Divine son, what do you think? Where do these flowers rest?"

He answered: "Mañjuśrī, these flowers have no resting place."

Mañjuśrī said: "In just the same way, divine son, all phenomena have no resting place. Without resting, they abide in space, and they neither rise up from space nor fall down, neither move nor tremble, neither stir nor shake."

"Why is that? Because all those phenomena are like unto space, and therefore they neither move nor tremble, neither stir nor shake."

Then the divine son Raśmirājadhvaja said to the youthful Mañjuśrī: "Mañjuśrī, you have obtained the miraculous power of supernatural ability. It is wondrous that with a single arising of thought you travel to and fro among inconceivably many buddha-fields throughout the ten directions, to the number of hundreds of thousands of ten million billions and beyond."

Mañjuśrī replied: "Divine son, I have not obtained any miraculous power of supernatural ability, and I am not a śrāvaka of the buddhas, the Blessed Ones. Why is that? Because such things are without exception and without exhaustion. Divine son, all ordinary persons who are like children are the ones who have obtained the miraculous power of supernatural ability. Why is that? Because, divine son, although all the buddhas, all the bodhisattvas, all the śrāvakas, and all the pratyekabuddhas have searched for innumerable eons, not a single phenomenon has been attained, is being attained, or will be attained. But all those ordinary persons who are like children do attain something. And what do they attain? They attain a self. They attain a sentient being, a life force, a born one, a nurturer, a person, one born of semen, offspring, annihilation, permanence, attachment, aversion, and delusion. Because they produce what the buddhas have not attained and have not generated, therefore, divine son, it is ordinary persons who are like children that have obtained miraculous power — not the buddhas, not the bodhisattvas, not the pratyekabuddhas, not the śrāvakas."

Then those blessed buddhas, the Blessed Ones, having explained at great length the categories of Dharma proper to the deliberations of buddhas, each departed to their own buddha-field.

Then the Tathāgata, King Praveśarāja, had this thought: "Let me create an auspicious sign so that Mañjuśrī, the youthful bodhisattva, will come to this buddha-field."

And so the Tathāgata King Praveśarāja sent forth that earlier blessing: from the palm of his right hand he drew out rays of light like the color of gold, and caused that light, by whatever means, to touch the body of Mañjuśrī the youthful bodhisattva, to circle him seven times, and finally to dissolve at the crown of Mañjuśrī's head. Thus was the blessing bestowed.

Then Mañjuśrī the youthful bodhisattva thought: "For what cause and by what condition has a light such as this, inconceivable, touched my body and then vanished at my crown?" And then he thought further: "The Tathāgata King Praveśarāja wishes to look upon me."

Then Mañjuśrī the youthful bodhisattva said to the divine son Raśmīketu: "Come, divine sons. Let us go to the buddha-field of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata King Praveśarāja, to behold that Tathāgata, to pay homage, to render service, and to make inquiry. And since the gateways of Dharma taught there are profound in their very profundity, they will be taught there, and we

should listen to them as well."

Then the divine son Raśmīketu said to Mañjuśrī the youthful bodhisattva: "Mañjuśrī, if you know the time has come, then let us depart."

Thereupon, with a single arising of mind, Mañjuśrī the youthful bodhisattva, from the peak of the surrounding mountain range, vanished together with those divine sons and appeared in the presence of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata King Praveśarāja.

Then Mañjuśrī the youthful bodhisattva bowed his head at the feet of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata King Praveśarāja, circumambulated him three times, and took a seat to one side. Those divine sons likewise bowed their heads at the feet of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened buddha King Praveśarāja, and took their seats to one side.

Then Mañjuśrī the youthful bodhisattva addressed the Blessed One, the Tathāgata King Praveśarāja, and said: "Blessed One, I will cause noble sons and noble daughters to properly cultivate roots of virtue. I will cause them to have no doubt in their acceptance of what is profound. And through this, I too will have become a worthy vessel. Why is this? Blessed One, it is thus: I have emerged from the midst of great elephants, as it were, and gone beyond them. I have also gone beyond teachings such as these. Blessed One, this sister who dispels doubt has not moved from this place on earth to any other, nor been flung to any other. Blessed One, I do not wish that in a single morning the Dharma teachings be dispersed or hurled into another world-realm. I have gone to buddha-fields in the eastern direction, as numerous as the grains of sand in the Gaṅgā, countless in number, and paid homage to those blessed buddhas, and have also received their Dharma teachings, making thorough inquiry of and thorough supplication to those blessed buddhas, and those Tathāgatas have in turn given me prophetic declaration in response to my inquiries. Blessed One, I do not wish that I be expelled from wherever the Dharma is being taught, or that I be flung into another world-realm."

All those blessed buddhas, knowing my intention, commanded me personally to teach the Dharma. Blessed One, when I arrived at the summit of the surrounding iron mountain range, my longing for the Dharma, my thirst for the Dharma, my reverence for the Dharma, and my longing for the Tathāgatas grew immeasurably. Then I thought to myself: "For what cause and by what

condition was I flung from that retinue to this summit of the iron mountain range, while my sister, the Dispeller of Doubt, was not flung there?" Blessed One, I then thought further: "A Tathāgata does not act with concealment toward phenomena in the manner of a teacher who withholds, nor does he have a mind of attachment. So then, is it that I myself am too limited, or that I have not become a suitable vessel for this Dharma teaching? That must be why I was flung there." So I resolved to ask the Tathāgata directly: "For what reason was I flung from this retinue to the summit of the iron mountains, while this sister was not flung there?" When I said these words, the Tathāgata, the King of Unimpeded Movement, spoke thus to Mañjuśrī, the youthful one:

"Mañjuśrī, there is nowhere at all that you have not become a suitable vessel for the Dharma teachings of the blessed buddhas. However, Mañjuśrī, the blessed buddhas are difficult to please, and at all times one is unable to respond adequately to another's practice of the Dharma. Mañjuśrī, right at the very beginning, when you arose from the world-realm called Abhirati, you thought to yourself: 'Today, in the world-realm called Universal Light, the blessed buddhas are teaching a discourse on the Dharma called Conversing with the Buddhas. I shall go there to see those blessed buddhas, to pay homage to them, to attend upon them, and to hear those Dharma teachings.' Mañjuśrī, it was with great boldness, great aim, great thought, and great deliberation that you set out from that buddha-field intending to go see the buddhas and to hear the Dharma. Mañjuśrī, you came from that buddha-field to this buddha-field bound by three attachments. What are these three? Attachment through apprehension of a self, attachment through apprehension of buddhas, and attachment through apprehension of the Dharma. Mañjuśrī, when a bodhisattva acts with apprehension, there is no attaining non-attachment. Mañjuśrī, what do you think? Is anyone able to know or see the Tathāgata, or to see any phenomenon apart from the Tathāgata?"

Mañjuśrī replied: "Blessed One, in terms of the nature of reality of all phenomena, I do not gaze upon the Tathāgata, nor upon the Dharma, nor upon sentient beings. Blessed One, if sentient beings were truly established, if a Tathāgata were to appear, and if one were to gaze upon the physical body of the Tathāgata, then one could indeed see the Tathāgata, and the Tathāgata too could see others. But Blessed One, because all phenomena are unborn, the one who gazes upon the Tathāgata does not exist, and the Tathāgata sees not even the slightest thing. Why is this so? Blessed One, all phenomena are not such as to be seen."

The Blessed One declared: "Mañjuśrī, is there even the slightest eye or ear with which one could wish to see the physical form of the Tathāgata or hear the Dharma of the Vinaya taught by the Tathāgata?"

Then Mañjuśrī, the youthful one, fell silent and said nothing.

Thereupon some among the bodhisattvas of that assembly of bodhisattvas thought to themselves:

"Mañjuśrī, the youthful one, has been wounded by the Tathāgata and, saying nothing, has been unable to respond to the wound the Tathāgata dealt him."

Then the Tathāgata, the King of Conquest over Craving, with the mind of a king, fully knowing the conceptual thoughts of those bodhisattvas, declared to them: "Sons of good family, do not think in that way. Do not give rise to a perception of contempt toward Mañjuśrī, the youthful one. Why is this? Mañjuśrī, the youthful one, possesses profound patience, and what the Tathāgata dealt as a wound has indeed been answered by Mañjuśrī, the youthful one."

Those bodhisattvas asked: "Blessed One, by what reasoning and in what manner was the wound answered?"

The Blessed One declared: "Sons of good family, Mañjuśrī thought to himself: 'If I were to say that I have an eye and that I have an ear, that would be falling into the view of permanence. If I were to say that I have no eye and no ear, that would be falling into the view of annihilation. By engaging in permanence and annihilation one cannot know the nature of reality, for in the nature of reality there is neither annihilation nor permanence. That which has neither annihilation nor permanence is unborn. That which is unborn is inexpressible.' Thinking in this way, Mañjuśrī, the youthful one, gave that as his answer to the wound."

When the Teacher taught this, six hundred bodhisattvas gave rise to the patient acceptance of the unborn nature of phenomena (Skt. *anutpattikadharmakṣānti*).

Then the Tathāgata, the King of Conquest over Craving, spoke these words to Mañjuśrī, the youthful one: "Mañjuśrī, it was for this cause and this condition that you were hurled to the summit of the encircling iron mountains. And why, Mañjuśrī, for what purpose? You said, 'May this sister Dispeller of Doubt not have been hurled away.' Mañjuśrī, this sister has entered into meditative absorption in the samādhi called 'Appearing Utterly Stainless in the Light of

the Moon.' Abiding in that samādhi, she does not think 'Are buddhas arriving here or not? Are they teaching the Dharma or not?' She has no perception of buddha, no perception of Dharma, no perception of Saṅgha, no perception of self, and no perception of other. Mañjuśrī, this sister is entirely free of all perceptions and mental engagements. Dwelling in that samādhi, she hears and holds the Dharma of all the buddhas and Blessed Ones of the ten directions, as many as the grains of sand in the Ganges River, and having heard it, she teaches it to others — yet, Mañjuśrī, this sister has no perception of realm as realm, no perception of buddha as buddha, no perception of Dharma as Dharma, no perception of Saṅgha as Saṅgha, no perception of self as self, no perception of other as other.

Mañjuśrī, it is like this: for example, the disk of the moon does not stir from its palace in the sky, yet it appears everywhere, it is shown everywhere, and yet the disk of the moon draws near to nothing. It has no conception of 'I shall let my light appear here' or 'I shall not let my light appear here.' Mañjuśrī, in just the same way, this sister abiding in this samādhi appears to countless sentient beings in boundless and limitless world-realms, teaches them in immeasurable buddha-fields, is without conceptual elaboration, holds her mind equal toward all sentient beings, and teaches the Dharma to all sentient beings.

Mañjuśrī, were I to speak of the qualities of this sister for a kalpa or the remainder of a kalpa without ceasing, the qualities would not be exhausted. Mañjuśrī, in this way, this sister is endowed with qualities that are inconceivable."

Mañjuśrī asked:

"Blessed One, what of the countless trillions of bodhisattvas present in this buddha-field? When the Blessed One — that buddha — gathers his assembly, are those bodhisattvas also cast away to other world-realms, just as I was?"

The Blessed One declared:

"Mañjuśrī, do not say such a thing. Do not conceptualize about the Tathāgata's wisdom. Do not conceptualize about the Tathāgata's emanations. Do not conceptualize about the Tathāgata's blessing. And why? Mañjuśrī, this great trichiliocosm — this vast world-realm of three thousand great thousands — is so thoroughly pervaded by buddhas, the Blessed Ones, assembled within it, that it is like a grove of sugarcane, or a thicket of reeds, or a bamboo forest, so many are those Tathāgatas filling it to the full. And yet all those bodhisattvas and gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, asuras, humans, and non-humans

dwelling in this buddha-field do not perceive anywhere, in any direction, any Tathāgata other than me. They see only me, singular and non-dual. Nor do they hear any teaching of the Dharma other than mine. They hear only my voice, singular.

Mañjuśrī, attend to the blessing of the Tathāgata, the miracle of the Tathāgata, the emanation of the Tathāgata, and the subtle body of the Tathāgata. Though the entire great trichiliocosm is filled with the bodies of the Tathāgata — and even those bodhisattvas with their divine eyes cannot see even a single Tathāgata among them — how much less would other sentient beings see them? That is utterly impossible. Mañjuśrī, attend to this: those countless bodies of the Tathāgata do not obstruct or impede the bodhisattvas, the gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, asuras, humans, and non-humans dwelling and moving about in this great trichiliocosm — whether they are walking, going, standing, sitting, or lying down, each acting just as they intend.

Mañjuśrī, understand this further by this category: the Tathāgata is the dharmakāya, the truth body — not a body constituted of fully formed material form. Mañjuśrī, the body of the Tathāgata is without defilement: it is like space — unborn, unarisen, unseen, unheard, unknowable by consciousness.

Mañjuśrī, consider this analogy: space is without defilement, without belonging, without form, not to be indicated, without obstruction, beyond discernment — and space cannot be seen by anyone. Nor can space be seen by the five eyes. What are the five eyes? They are the fleshly eye, the divine eye, the eye of wisdom, the eye of Dharma, and the eye of buddha. Apart from this, 'space' simply passes as a name, as a mere designation.

Mañjuśrī, in just the same way, the body of the Tathāgata too is without defilement, without belonging, without form, not to be indicated, without obstruction, beyond discernment — and no one can see the body of the Tathāgata. No one has ever seen the body of the Tathāgata. The body of the Tathāgata does not appear to the five eyes — from the fleshly eye through to the buddha's eye. Rather, 'Tathāgata' simply passes as a mere name, as a mere designation — and even that name is empty.

Mañjuśrī, attend now to the miracle of the Tathāgata."

The Tathāgatas are like space, and yet they display the full perfection of the color and form of the physical body, and they are endowed with the thirty-two marks of a great being. Mañjuśrī, all of those Tathāgatas whom you were unable to see with your eye — it came to be that way through the blessing and

power of those very Tathāgatas. And why? Because, Mañjuśrī the Youthful, it is you, and beginning from you the profound Dharma will be taught.

Then all the bodhisattvas dwelling in that buddha-field cried out together with a single voice in amazement: "Wondrous! Wondrous! How great is the miraculous power of the Tathāgatas, how great their might — that although the Tathāgatas are many, we have not seen even a single Tathāgata. No sign whatsoever appeared to us of who came, who departed, who presided, who taught. And yet here we see one single Tathāgata teaching."

"Blessed One, for the sake of such great wisdom, even if a great bodhisattva were to endure the great hells for as many eons as there are grains of sand in the Ganges for each and every sentient being, Blessed One, a great bodhisattva would bear that. Such great wisdom is something one would never abandon."

Then Mañjuśrī the Youthful spoke these words to the Tathāgata, the King Who Delights in Engagement: "Blessed One, ever since this sister generated the mind set on unsurpassed, complete, perfect awakening, she has thereby attained such a peaceful and supreme meditative absorption. How long has she dwelt in it?"

The Blessed One declared: "The unsurpassed, complete, perfect awakening of the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, is generated over immeasurable eons — arising continuously, arising boundlessly, born of generosity, moral discipline, patience, diligence, meditative concentration, and wisdom. Such is the unsurpassed, complete, perfect awakening of the buddhas, the Blessed Ones. This sister, Mañjuśrī, has practiced for a long time, has rendered service to the Victors of former times, and has cultivated roots of virtue. Indeed, this sister has attended upon many hundreds of thousands of tens of millions of buddhas. Now, Mañjuśrī, you ask her how long she has been dwelling in this absorption, and invite her to arise from it — for this very sister will teach it to you."

This is the third and final fascicle.

Then Mañjuśrī the Youthful, wishing to rouse that sister from her absorption, rang a finger-snap in the ordinary way, yet that sister did not rise from that absorption. Then Mañjuśrī the Youthful produced a finger-snap of such a kind that its sound would be heard throughout the world-systems of the ten directions, boundless and limitless — yet that sister still did not rise from that absorption. Then Mañjuśrī the Youthful manifested a display of miraculous

power, a performance of wondrous feats, such that all the musical instruments of gods and humans throughout the great trichiliocosm resounded without being struck; and he himself emanated many hundreds of thousands of tens of millions of musical instruments and drew forth from them sounds pleasing and enchanting to the ear. And then too there arose an exceedingly great sound from those musical instruments, a sound that resounded throughout the boundless and limitless world-systems of the ten directions — yet that sister did not rise from that absorption.

At that very time, the attendants of mine who were present with the Blessed Ones, the buddhas abiding in all ten directions, asked of those Blessed Ones: "For what cause and by what condition has this sound of musical instruments — a sound such as the Blessed One has never before heard — arisen in the world?" When they had spoken thus, those Tathāgatas declared to my attendants: "There is a world-realm called Universally Radiant. There dwells the Tathāgata known as the King Who Enters into Craving, living and well. In the buddha-field of that Tathāgata, a sister named Dispeller of Doubt is established in meditative absorption called Appearance of the Moon's Light, Pure and Undefined, on the right side of that Tathāgata. There, there is a bodhisattva called Mañjuśrī, Prince of the Dharma, who is irreversible and has donned inconceivable armor. Wishing to rouse that sister from her absorption, this son of good family, Mañjuśrī, Prince of the Dharma, drew forth the sounds of the musical instruments of gods and humans; and through his blessing, those musical instruments sounded without being struck. Moreover, in order to rouse that sister from her absorption, he emanated many hundreds of thousands of tens of millions of musical instruments. These too, sons of good family, sounded without being struck — yet he was unable to rouse that sister from her absorption. It is for that cause and that condition, sons of good family, that this great sound of musical instruments has arisen in the world." When they had spoken thus, those attendants addressed the Blessed Ones, the buddhas, saying: "Blessed One, it is wondrous that this sister has attained such a peaceful absorption and does not rise even when such a sound of musical instruments arises." The Blessed Ones declared: "So it is, sons of good family. This sister has attained an inconceivable meditative absorption."

Then, as this account was being told, innumerable and immeasurable sentient beings from the ten directions entered upon unsurpassed awakening, saying: "Just as that sister has done, may we too attain such a peaceful absorption. Just as Mañjuśrī, Prince of the Dharma, has done, may we too attain such a

power of emanation."

Then once more, Mañjuśrī, Prince of the Dharma, performed a display of miraculous power — a display of such a kind that throughout the world-system of the great trichiliocosm, Mount Meru, the king of mountains, together with the snow mountains, the lesser surrounding ranges, the greater surrounding ranges, the iron encircling mountains, the great iron encircling mountains, and all the other mountains, great and small — all of these were gathered together one against another, crashing into one another and colliding with one another. It was as when a great powerful man claps his hands against an opponent of equal power with the full force of his might — so too those great mountains and great encircling iron mountain ranges were gathered together one against another, and those kings of mountains let out a terrifying sound and cry that caused the hairs of the body to stand on end, a sound that resounded throughout boundless and limitless world-systems in the ten directions. Yet even when he had performed such a display of miraculous power, he was unable to rouse that sister from her absorption.

Then Mañjuśrī, Prince of the Dharma, without physically touching that sister with his two hands, yet through his blessing taking hold of her two hands, wished to raise her up. As he moved to do so, the buddha-fields of the lower direction equal in number to the grains of sand of the Ganges River were shaken and greatly shaken.

Yet even though the entire world shook and trembled greatly in this way, Mañjuśrī was unable to rouse that sister. He could not move or stir even a hair's-breadth of her, not even the tip of a single hair. Unable to raise her from that meditative absorption, he resolved to exert himself with all his might, and so he lifted her with full force — and yet, even as the buddha-fields equal in number to the grains of sand of the Ganges River were hurled upward, she did not rise from that meditative absorption.

Then Mañjuśrī, Prince of the Dharma, carried that sister to whichever direction she was resting in meditative equipoise, bearing her along the full circuit of that very direction, and placed her upon his right hand. Holding her on his right hand, he flung her all the way up to the world of Brahmā — yet that sister did not rise from that meditative absorption. From the world of Brahmā he brought her back down and placed her upon the ground again — still she did not rise.

Then Mañjuśrī, Prince of the Dharma, placed that sister upon his right hand and traveled eastward through buddha-fields equal in number to the grains of sand of the Ganges River, filling the air with those melodious sounds and those mountain harmonies, and raining down a shower of flowers as he went — yet that sister did not rise from that meditative absorption.

In the same way he carried her throughout the south, the west, the north, and through all the world-systems of the ten directions, and then placed her back in that very same spot. With palms joined together in reverence, he addressed the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the King Praveśarāja, saying this:

"Blessed One, the conduct of bodhisattvas is truly wondrous — it is not something that can be easily perceived or even conceived by all sentient beings. Blessed One, if it were possible for me to speak of things that are beyond the mind, I would speak of them — yet I was unable to rouse this sister with such sounds of miracles, magical displays, and wondrous feats. Blessed One, I pay homage to this sister and to all who have entered, who are entering, and who are working to accomplish the great gnosis of supreme, perfect, unsurpassable awakening — for theirs is conduct of this very kind. And why is that? Blessed One, this conduct of bodhisattvas is the conduct of the Great Vinaya."

In the very act of attempting to rouse that sister from her meditative absorption — carrying her throughout all ten directions — Mañjuśrī, Prince of the Dharma, brought immeasurable sentient beings to full ripening for awakening. The roots of virtue of immeasurable sentient beings were fully perfected.

When these words had been spoken, the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the King Praveśarāja, addressed Mañjuśrī, Prince of the Dharma, with these words:

"It is just as you have said, Mañjuśrī. The armor of bodhisattvas is inconceivable. If even śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas cannot easily comprehend it, what need is there to speak of other sentient beings?

Mañjuśrī, consider this example: suppose this entire great trichiliocosm world-system were to become a single drum-face, and further suppose that yet another single great trichiliocosm world-system were likewise to become a single drum-face — take the full measure of them together. Mañjuśrī, if there were a great drum of such proportions, and a person of corresponding strength and power, endowed with a body of such a kind, were to take up a drumstick equal in size to a single chiliocosm world-system and, standing

before that sister, were to beat that great drum for an entire eon or even the remainder of an eon — if that sound would still not reach the ears of that sister, how much less would she be roused from her meditative absorption! That is impossible. That sister has attained a meditative absorption of such peace as this."

Then Mañjuśrī addressed him, saying:

"Blessed One, who is able to rouse this sister from this meditative absorption?" The Blessed One declared: "Mañjuśrī, apart from a Tathāgata or the bodhisattva Sarvanivaraṇaviṣkambhin, there is no one else able to rouse this sister from this meditative absorption."

Then, the very instant the name of that son of good family was spoken, the great trichiliocosm world-system trembled in six ways. And then, the bodhisattva named Pramuditārāja, a servant of the Tathāgata King of Passionate Engagement, addressed that Tathāgata, saying: "Blessed One, by what cause and by what condition did this great earth tremble?" The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, the very instant the name of the bodhisattva Sarvanivaraṇaviṣkambhin is spoken, the great trichiliocosm world-system will certainly tremble — and in whatever other world-systems Tathāgatas speak the name of that son of good family, at that very instant, the great earth trembles in six ways."

Then the bodhisattvas in that assembly longed to see the bodhisattva Sarvanivaraṇaviṣkambhin. Mañjuśrī, youthful in appearance, also wished to see that bodhisattva. Then youthful Mañjuśrī, knowing that those bodhisattvas all longed deeply to see him, and wishing himself to see him and also to rouse that sister from her meditative absorption, addressed the Tathāgata, the King of Passionate Engagement, in these words: "Blessed One, please be so kind as to display the supernatural power by which I may come to see the bodhisattva Sarvanivaraṇaviṣkambhin. Since this assembly also wishes to see that son of good family, Blessed One, and since I too wish to see that holy person, please display such supernatural transformations that that person may come to this buddha field, that beginning from that son of good family the profound Dharma will be taught, that these bodhisattvas may see that bodhisattva and, upon seeing him, train in his ways, and that this sister may rise from her meditative absorption."

Then the bodhisattva Pramuditārāja addressed the Blessed One, the Tathāgata King of Passionate Engagement, in these words: "Blessed One, in

which direction, in which buddha field, does that son of good family presently dwell? And what is the name of the Tathāgata in that buddha field?" The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, in the downward direction, past as many buddha fields from this buddha field as there are grains of sand in the river Gaṅgā, there exists a world-system called Banner of Manifold Realms. There dwells a Tathāgata named He Who Proclaims the Sound of the Mass of the Lion, the Goose, and the Bull-Elephant, living and teaching the Dharma. And there the bodhisattva called Sarvanivaraṇaviṣkambhin presently abides."

Then, at that moment, as the Tathāgata King of Passionate Engagement sat upon his throne, he sent forth from the great toe of his right foot a ray of light called Arouser of Bodhisattvas. The instant that light was sent forth, it pierced through buddha fields in the downward direction equal in number to the grains of sand of the Gaṅgā and fell upon the body of the bodhisattva Sarvanivaraṇaviṣkambhin. It circled that son of good family three times and then disappeared into the crown of his head.

Then the bodhisattva Sarvanivaraṇaviṣkambhin, by what cause and by what condition —

because that pure light had circled him seven times and then disappeared into the crown of his head, he thought to himself: "The Tathāgata King of Passionate Engagement wishes to look upon me." Then the bodhisattva Sarvanivaraṇaviṣkambhin, with a voice like the combined roar of lions, swans, and wild oxen, went to where the Tathāgata was, arrived there, and prostrated with his head at the Blessed One's feet. He then addressed him thus: "Blessed One, I wish to behold the Blessed One, the Tathāgata King of Passionate Engagement, in the upward direction." The Blessed One declared, "If you know the time has come, then go."

Then the Blessed One, the Tathāgata whose name is Roar of Lions, Swans, and Wild Oxen, was addressed by his attendant, whose name is Accomplisher of All Goals, who said to him: "Blessed One, I wish to behold the Tathāgata King of Passionate Engagement." Thereupon the Tathāgata Roar of Lions, Swans, and Wild Oxen, at that very moment, sent forth light from the tuft of hair between his brows. That light pierced through buddha fields in the upward direction equal in number to the grains of sand of the Gaṅgā, and throughout the entire world-system called All-Light it appeared as though shining from itself — just as it had arisen — revealing the Tathāgata King of Passionate Engagement teaching the Dharma, surrounded by many bodhisattvas, like a mountain of

gold beside the river of Jambudvīpa. And just as a single clear-eyed person standing an arm's length away might examine the form of another person, in exactly that way the entire retinue saw the Tathāgata King of Passionate Engagement together with his Saṅgha of bodhisattvas.

Then the bodhisattva Sarvanivaraṇaviṣkambhin, generating a single mind together with five hundred thousand bodhisattvas, vanished from that buddha field and came to dwell in the world-system called All-Light. He prostrated with his head at the feet of the Tathāgata King of Passionate Engagement and sat in his presence.

Then the bodhisattva Sarvanivaraṇaviṣkambhin, together with those bodhisattvas, made his body invisible, prostrated with his head at the feet of that Blessed One, and circumambulated the Blessed One three times. He then remained suspended in the sky above, entering into meditative absorption in the samādhi called Tormenting All Bodies.

Thereupon the bodhisattva Sarvanivaraṇaviṣkambhin, through what manner of auspicious sign, caused a rain of divine flowers to fall from the sky above. Those flowers fell at the feet of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata King of Passionate Engagement. And from those flowers came a voice — like the roar of lions, swans, and wild oxen — saying to the Tathāgata: "Does the Blessed One suffer no illness, no faintness? Does he rise? Is he well? Does he possess power? Does he abide in the touch of ease?" Such was the auspicious sign he performed, causing words of that kind to arise.

The entire retinue was then struck with wonder, and they uttered these words: "Blessed One, by whose power are flowers such as these raining down and announcing such pleasing sounds?" Then the youthful Mañjuśrī addressed the Tathāgata King of Passionate Engagement and said: "Blessed One, by whose power do these flowers rain down and from them come forth such pleasing sounds?" The Blessed One declared, "Mañjuśrī, it is by the power of the bodhisattva Sarvanivaraṇaviṣkambhin." He then continued:

The Blessed One was then asked, "Blessed One, where is the bodhisattva Sarvanivaraṇaviṣkambhin?" The Blessed One declared, "Mañjuśrī, the bodhisattva Sarvanivaraṇaviṣkambhin is dwelling in the sky above. Accompanied by five hundred thousand bodhisattvas, he is paying homage at my feet, and in the sky above he has entered into meditative absorption in the samādhi called the Suppression of All Bodies."

Mañjuśrī then said, "Blessed One, those bodhisattvas are not to be seen." The Blessed One declared, "They cannot be seen because of the power of the bodhisattva Sarvanivaraṇaviṣkambhin."

Then the youthful Mañjuśrī formed this thought: "I too shall enter into meditative absorption in the samādhi of the Suppression of All Bodies. Having entered that samādhi, I shall search out that holy being Sarvanivaraṇaviṣkambhin and those bodhisattvas."

Now the bodhisattva Sarvanivaraṇaviṣkambhin, perceiving with his mind the conceptual thought in the mind of the youthful Mañjuśrī, made his body invisible in the sky and spoke thus to the youthful Mañjuśrī: "Mañjuśrī, what do you think? Do not regard the samādhi called the Suppression of All Bodies as being just one single samādhi. Why is this? Mañjuśrī, in the vast great ocean, however many masses of water there are, however many drops of water there are in all of that — that is how many times I can enter into and arise from the samādhi of the Suppression of All Bodies. You do not even know their names."

Then the youthful Mañjuśrī formed this thought: "If I do not accomplish that samādhi, all my previous training has been for nothing." And so the youthful Mañjuśrī then and there applied himself with exactly the kind of diligence through which one single moment would bring accomplishment.

Thereupon the Tathāgata King of Passionate Engagement declared to those bodhisattvas: "Sons of good family, the youthful Mañjuśrī has accomplished in a single moment the samādhi that no other bodhisattva could accomplish even in ten trillion aeons. Look to the excellence of his training in heightened intention."

Then the youthful Mañjuśrī addressed the Tathāgata King of Passionate Engagement and said: "Blessed One, if this assembly wishes to see those holy beings and that bodhisattva, please reveal them." The Blessed One then said to the bodhisattva Sarvanivaraṇaviṣkambhin: "This assembly wishes to see you. Son of good family, please reveal your body."

Thereupon the bodhisattva Sarvanivaraṇaviṣkambhin descended from the sky, bowed once more with his head at the feet of the Blessed One, and accompanied by those bodhisattvas, made his body invisible, and said to the youthful Mañjuśrī: "Do you see me?" Mañjuśrī replied, "I do not see you."

Then the Tathāgata King of Passionate Engagement said to the bodhisattva Sarvanivaraṇaviṣkambhin: "Son of good family, these beings and this

assembly wish to see your body. Son of good family, please reveal your body."

Thereupon the bodhisattva Sarvanivaraṇaviṣkambhin, accompanied by those five hundred thousand bodhisattvas, revealed himself with a body adorned with the fullness of a physical form.

Then the youthful Mañjuśrī said to the bodhisattva Sarvanivaraṇaviṣkambhin: "Son of good family, rouse this sister from this meditative absorption." He replied: "Mañjuśrī, you said 'rouse this sister from this meditative absorption' — but is it a name that is to be roused? Or is it form, feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness that are to be roused? Mañjuśrī, the intrinsic nature of form is not placed in equipoise. The intrinsic nature of feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness is likewise neither placed in equipoise nor caused to arise. Mañjuśrī, whatever is the intrinsic nature of all phenomena — that is neither placed in equipoise nor caused to arise. So what thing is there to be roused? Mañjuśrī, if this sister were to be placed in equipoise, then for that reason she could be roused. But Mañjuśrī, this sister has not been placed in equipoise even slightly. Why is that? Because all phenomena are without motion and without activity."

Then the Tathāgata King of Passionate Engagement declared to the bodhisattva Sarvanivaraṇaviṣkambhin: "Son of good family, rouse this sister from this meditative absorption." He replied: "Blessed One, I have no power to rouse her by bowing my head in reverence. Since the Tathāgata has said, 'Direct your virtue toward it,' may the Tathāgata himself rouse this sister." He then said: "Blessed One, although I have the power to rouse this sister from this meditative absorption, the Tathāgatas are skilled in knowing and teaching all phenomena — therefore may the Tathāgata himself rouse this sister."

Thereupon the Tathāgata King of Passionate Engagement entered into the meditative absorption called Causing the Mind to Arise from Meditative Absorption. As soon as the Tathāgata had entered into equipoise, all those in that great trichilocosm — gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas (dri za), and bodhisattvas — however many there were in meditative equipoise, all of them arose. That sister likewise arose from her meditative absorption, and upon arising, caused the great earth to tremble in six ways, and then sat in the space above.

At that moment many hundreds of thousands of sons of gods assembled together. Then that sister, sitting in the space above, scattered upon the body of the Tathāgata flowers of utpala, kumuda, and puṇḍarīka.

Then the youthful Mañjuśrī said to the sister Vimatīsamprasupta: "Sister, it is wonderful that you have attained such a peaceful meditative absorption." She replied: "Mañjuśrī, do not say such things, and do not engage in conceptual thought. I have not attained a peaceful meditative absorption. Why is that? It is generated through not having attained the awakening of the buddhas, the Blessed Ones. Mañjuśrī, where there is attainment, there is also an object of reference. Mañjuśrī, all phenomena are peaceful, utterly peaceful, thoroughly peaceful — and that peace is not something to be made peaceful. Peace is neither placed in equipoise nor caused to arise."

Mañjuśrī said: "Sister, that is so — it is just as you have said. Yet you have attained a vast meditative absorption, for even the sound of great music did not cause you to arise." She replied: "Mañjuśrī, does the dharmadhātu have equipoise or arising?" He said: "Sister, it does not." She replied: "Mañjuśrī, can that which has not been placed in equipoise be caused to arise?" He said: "It cannot." She replied: "Mañjuśrī, those things that are without color, mark, shape, and sign — those are placed in equipoise. And that which is without color —

mark, shape, or sign — where are those placed in equipoise? Mañjuśrī, those things are placed in equipoise by their very intrinsic nature at all times. They cannot be placed in equipoise again, nor caused to arise. Therefore, Mañjuśrī, take heed.

Mañjuśrī, consider this analogy: if all the musical instruments of gods and humans were played at once, would a pleasing sound arise?" He said: "Sister, it is so." "Mañjuśrī, would one then think that the element of space itself produces a pleasing sound from those instruments?" He said: "Sister, it would not." "Mañjuśrī, therefore, since all phenomena are like space, who would hear a sound in this? Only one who has consciousness hears — and it ends there with hearing."

He said: "Sister, do you not have ears with which you heard that sound?" At that, the sister fell silent. He said: "Sister, why do you not speak?" She said: "I do not hear." He said: "Why?" She said: "Because no ear is apprehended."

Furthermore, the sister who resolves doubt then spoke thus to Mañjuśrī, the youthful: "Mañjuśrī, consider this analogy: when a great whirlwind of wind arises and causes great trees to sway, no one can see the wind itself, and it too is without conceptual thought — the wind does not think, 'I will move these trees,' and the trees too do not think, 'We are being moved by the wind.'"

Mañjuśrī, in the same way, a bodhisattva who is practicing the Perfection of Wisdom and who has abandoned all conceptual thought does not think, 'I shall enter into equipoise and arise from it.' Why? Because all phenomena are by their intrinsic nature empty of inherent existence."

Mañjuśrī said: "Sister, descend from the sky above and sit in the presence of the Tathāgata and speak." The sister replied: "Mañjuśrī, my own domain is here. I have no wish for another's domain." He said: "Sister, what is your own domain?" She said: "Mañjuśrī, the expanse of space is the domain of all sentient beings. Why? Because all sentient beings come and go through space; whatever the range of a sentient being's activity, all of it moves within space. Therefore space is the domain of all sentient beings — and so it is: this seal of space is the seal of all phenomena."

Then the sister descended from the sky above and sat to one side upon a lotus. She did not bow her head at the feet of the Tathāgata, and she did not speak a word. Then Mañjuśrī, the youthful, said to the sister: "Sister, you sit there without paying homage to the Tathāgata — that is disrespectful." She said: "Mañjuśrī, that is so — Mañjuśrī, I am indeed disrespectful. Why? In this way, there is neither any doing nor any not-doing. In that way I am disrespectful — but Mañjuśrī, can one pay homage to suchness?" He said: "One cannot." She said: "Then neither can one pay homage to the Tathāgata. Why? Because the Tathāgata and suchness are not two; they are inseparable, as if one and the same."

She said further: "Mañjuśrī, do you see the Tathāgata?" He said: "I do." She said: "How do you see him?" He said: "I see him in the way that not even a particle is seen — in just that way I see." She said: "If you see in that way, what do you see?" He said: "Seeing in that way, I see not even the slightest thing." She said:

"Mañjuśrī, if you do not see even the slightest thing, does that mean your eyes are dull?" He said: "I am neither one with dull eyes, nor one possessed of the five eyes, nor one without eyes. Why is that? Sister, the eye is unborn, not truly arisen — it is like an illusion. Because all phenomena are without inherent existence, it cannot be described as either existent or nonexistent."

She said: "Mañjuśrī, do you then hold that all phenomena are without inherent existence?" He said: "They are neither existent nor nonexistent." She said: "Mañjuśrī, it is exactly as you have said."

Then the youthful Mañjuśrī said this to the sister: "Why do you not transform away from a woman's body?" She said: "Mañjuśrī, do not speak like that. Do not discriminate. Do you see any phenomenon that has come into being as male or as female?" He said: "I do not." She said: "Mañjuśrī, what do you think — is form male or female?" He said: "It is not." "Are feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness male or female?" He said: "They are not." "Mañjuśrī, what do you think — is the eye male or female? Are the ear, nose, tongue, body, and mind male or female?" He said: "They are not." "Mañjuśrī, what do you think — is the earth element male or female?" He said: "It is not." "Are the water element, the fire element, the wind element, the space element, and the consciousness element male or female?" He said: "They are not." "Mañjuśrī, what do you think — through whatever syllables speech is spoken, can those very syllables be apprehended as male or as female?" He said: "They cannot."

She said: "Mañjuśrī, then how is it that you ask why I have not transformed away from a woman's body? Mañjuśrī, if I perceived myself as female or saw myself as male, I might abandon that woman's body and take on a male body. But Mañjuśrī, since I perceive myself neither as female nor do I see myself as male, how could I transform away from a woman's body? Mañjuśrī, the dharmadhātu neither arises nor perishes. Suchness, the absolute limit, emptiness, and the expanse of space likewise neither arise nor perish. When all phenomena are equal to space in this way, how could one be capable of abandoning a woman's body and taking on a male body? Why? Because the Tathāgata does not teach the Dharma on the basis of taking up or setting aside. And again, Mañjuśrī, the Tathāgata has taught that the eye is neither male nor female, and likewise the ear, nose, tongue, body, and mind are neither male nor female. Whatever phenomenon is neither male nor female, that phenomenon neither arises nor perishes."

He said: "Sister, for how long have you given rise to the awakening mind aimed at the highest, perfect, and complete awakening?" She said: "For as long as an illusory man is conscious." He said: "Does an illusory man exist?" She said: "He does not." He said: "Then why do you speak thus? Has forbearance arisen in you?" She said: "It has not." He said: "Then why do you teach?" She said: "For as long as an illusory man gives rise to the awakening mind aimed at awakening, for that long I have given rise to the awakening mind aimed at awakening. Why? Because all phenomena are like an illusion. Moreover, your question — 'for how long have you given rise to the awakening

mind?' — is not in accordance with the genuine way of things."

Why is that? Because non-arising cannot be produced, cannot be negated, and cannot be designated. A phenomenon that has no object of negation cannot be produced or negated. He said: "What is a question in accordance with the genuine way of things, and what is that way?" She said: "Non-arising is the way, and to ask in a manner consonant with that — like to like — is to ask in accordance with the genuine way of things."

Again he asked: "Sister, has forbearance arisen in you?" She said: "Forbearance has not arisen in me, nor has it not arisen." Why? Because forbearance is not apprehended as an object, it has neither been produced nor diminished. Therefore forbearance has neither arisen in me nor not arisen.

"Sister, upon seeing the benefit of what does a bodhisattva enter into unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening?" She said: "Mañjuśrī, for the sake of thoroughly liberating sentient beings from suffering, a bodhisattva dons the armor of awakening. Why? Because, Mañjuśrī, all phenomena have been in nirvāṇa from the very beginning. The perfectly and completely awakened buddhas of the past have not liberated any sentient being whatsoever, those yet to come will not liberate any sentient being, and those presently abiding do not liberate any sentient being either. Why? Because there are no sentient beings."

He said: "Sister, why then do buddhas appear?" Mañjuśrī said: "Buddhas appear because there is nothing to do and nothing being done." He said: "Why so?" She said: "Because in this there is not the slightest thing to be done."

He said: "Sister, why does one go forth, receive full ordination, and become a fully ordained monk?" She said: "In order to complete the five acts of immediate consequence." He said: "Sister, who would have faith in that?" She said: "Those whose wisdom has arisen and is indestructible." He said: "Who would have devotion toward that?" She said: "Those who have devotion." He said: "Sister, what virtue is there in devotion?" She said: "Mañjuśrī, devotion has the virtue of liberation." He said: "Sister, it is wonderful that you are endowed with the virtue of unobstructed confidence." She said: "Mañjuśrī, do not make an object of it. Is there attachment anywhere at all, Mañjuśrī? Therefore do not say to me that I am endowed with unobstructed eloquence." He said: "That is not so." She said: "Therefore I am not endowed with unobstructed eloquence."

He said: "Sister, what is called 'eloquence' — in what is it called eloquence?" She said: "Those who have realization have eloquence." He said: "Where is realization?" She said: "Realization is by virtue of not realizing anywhere at all — not realizing the dharmadhātu, suchness, or the absolute limit — that is therefore called realization." She said: "Mañjuśrī, I too have realized what others have not realized." He said: "Where is it not realized?" She said: "It is not realized in the three realms. Those who have not realized it in the three realms — it is by not having penetrated it that they realize it."

He said: "Sister, when will you fully and completely awaken to awakening?" She said: "When the Tathāgata, the King Priyaṃkara, fully and completely awakens, then I too shall fully and completely awaken. But Mañjuśrī — can one fully awaken to awakening, can one attain it?"

Then Mañjuśrī, the youthful one, fell silent. And that sister spoke thus: "Mañjuśrī, the time has not yet come for silence — speak!" Mañjuśrī said: "Sister, awakening is beyond description, so why do you seek something to be said?" Then Mañjuśrī, the youthful one, addressed the Tathāgata, the King Priyaṃkara, as follows.

"Blessed One, this sister possesses inconceivable wisdom and teaches the Dharma in this manner. How wondrous her deeds! Blessed One, from how long ago did this sister arouse the mind of unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening? How long until she will fully and perfectly awaken to awakening? What will her buddha-field be like? And what will her name be?"

The Blessed One declared: "This sister, having practiced for the sake of awakening, passed through ninety-nine times one hundred thousand tens of millions of one hundred thousand times one hundred thousand immeasurable eons. After all that, you yourself aroused the mind of awakening."

Mañjuśrī asked: "What is the name of the Tathāgata in whose presence this sister aroused the mind of awakening?"

The Blessed One declared: "Mañjuśrī, a Tathāgata appeared whose name was Jewel-Arising. It was in the presence of the Tathāgata Jewel-Arising that she aroused the mind of awakening. The assembled qualities of that Tathāgata's buddha-field — even were one to describe them for as many eons as there are grains of sand in the river Ganges, one could not describe even a fraction of them. And it was there that this sister aroused the mind of awakening."

Mañjuśrī asked: "Was she then a woman?"

The Blessed One declared: "No — for at that time and in that age, she was a wheel-turning king named Free from Sound. Mañjuśrī, one should not call this sister a woman, nor should one call her a man. She has attained the meditative absorption that is like an illusion, and in accordance with her wish she causes her body to appear as an emanation."

"Mañjuśrī, this sister will fully and perfectly awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening over a span of immeasurable eons numbering one hundred thousand times as many as the grains of dust, branches, and leaves in a great trichiliocosm — a billion-world universe. She will appear in a buddha-field adorned with a great assembly of qualities, as the Tathāgata, the Blessed One, the buddha known as Bestower of Universal Radiance. And that buddha-field will be exactly like the buddha-field of the Tathāgata Jewel-Arising — neither exceeding it nor falling short of it."

Then the bodhisattva Dispeller of All Obscurations addressed the Tathāgata, the King Priyaṃkara, as follows: "Blessed One, Mañjuśrī the youthful one has done and does many things, and he comprehends phenomena of the past and the future as well."

Mañjuśrī said: "Noble son, it is so — it is just as you have said. Indeed, I do many things, and those actions will never be exhausted, for the dharmadhātu, the basic space of phenomena, is inexhaustible."

Then the Tathāgata, the King Priyaṃkara, addressed Mañjuśrī the youthful one thus: "Mañjuśrī, do not dispute with the bodhisattva Dispeller of All Obscurations. Why? Because this noble son is endowed with inconceivable confidence and powers of inquiry. As for the meditative absorptions with which the bodhisattva Dispeller of All Obscurations dwells in equipoise, and the equanimous states in which he is established — even their mere names you do not know."

Then the foremost bodhisattva among the retinue present there thought to himself: "How wonderful! The bodhisattva Dispeller of All Obscurations will surely be praised by the Tathāgatas!"

Then the Blessed One, knowing the minds of those bodhisattvas with his own mind,

spoke to the bodhisattva Very Gentle Mind, saying: "Noble son, even if all the sentient beings in this great trichiliocosm were to become the equal of Mañjuśrī, they would still not be capable of matching even a hundredth part,

let alone a thousandth part, of this sister's power of meditative absorption, her magical transformations, her miraculous displays, and her primordial wisdom. Moreover, even the mere names of the meditative absorptions into which this sister enters equipoise and from which she arises — even those Mañjuśrī does not know.

"Noble son, even if all the sentient beings in this great trichiliocosm were to become like those who, through the power of meditative absorption and primordial wisdom, entering equipoise, dispel all doubt — even all of them together would not be capable of matching even a hundredth part, let alone a thousandth part, of the bodhisattva Dispeller of All Obscurations' meditative absorptions, primordial wisdom, powers, and magical transformations. Indeed, this sister does not know even the mere names of those meditative absorptions into which the bodhisattva Dispeller of All Obscurations enters equipoise and from which he arises.

"Noble son, even if all sentient beings were to enter equipoise through meditative absorption and primordial wisdom, dispelling all obscurations, and were thereby endowed with that primordial wisdom — still they would not know how to take even a single step of the Tathāgata; they would be lost in confusion, not knowing how the Tathāgata lifts his foot to step forward, nor how he places it down. Noble son, in this way the primordial wisdom of a buddha is inconceivable.

"While this teaching on the inconceivability of the buddha's primordial wisdom was being set forth, seventy million living beings gave rise to the mind of unsurpassable, perfect, and complete awakening, and each declared with their own voice, 'May we too come to be endowed with that primordial wisdom.'

Then the Blessed One spoke again to the bodhisattva Very Gentle Mind: "Noble son, this sister has caused the bodhisattva Mañjuśrī Kumārabhūta to give rise to the mind of awakening. And bodhisattvas comparable to Mañjuśrī Kumārabhūta exist to the east in numbers equal to the sands of the Ganges, and equally so to the south, to the west, to the north, and in all ten directions.

"Noble son, the bodhisattva Dispeller of All Obscurations has caused this sister to give rise to the mind of awakening. And this noble son has caused bodhisattvas comparable to this sister — equal in number to the sands of the Ganges — to give rise to the mind of awakening in the eastern direction. The same holds throughout all ten directions.

"Noble son, do you see that I myself have now fully and completely awakened to unsurpassable, perfect awakening, and that I, as a Tathāgata, have turned the wheel of Dharma? Noble son, I too, in a past time, was caused by the bodhisattva Dispeller of All Obscurations, through the scriptural transmission of the Tathāgata Victorious Banner of Sumeru, to give rise to the mind of awakening. And just as I am, so also Tathāgatas equal in number to the sands of the Ganges were caused by him to give rise to the mind of awakening throughout the ten directions. Some of them dwell and are alive at present; and immeasurable numbers of them have already passed fully into nirvāṇa."

The moment these words were spoken, the great trichiliocosm trembled in six ways. And while this exposition of the Dharma was being taught, in the world-realm called Universally Luminous, ninety-two billion bodhisattvas attained patient acceptance of the truth that phenomena do not arise.

In this world-realm as well, the enumeration of this Dharma resounded in the sense faculties of the ears of those sentient beings whose intentions were utterly pure. The bodhisattva Maitreya received it completely, without remainder and without interruption. In this world-realm, too, sixty-four billion living beings, upon hearing this enumeration of the Dharma, gave rise to the mind directed toward unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Seventy thousand bodhisattvas attained patient acceptance of the truth that phenomena do not arise. Fourteen thousand monks liberated their minds from all defilements without remainder. Five thousand nuns, together with sixty-six billion gods, humans, and other sentient beings, obtained the pure, stainless Dharma-eye — unsullied and freed from all defilement — regarding all phenomena.

Then the Blessed One, the Tathāgata Śākyamuni, addressed the bodhisattva Maitreya: "Invincible One (Ajita), receive this enumeration of the Dharma and expound it extensively to others."

Maitreya replied: "Blessed One, I have received this enumeration of the Dharma."

The Blessed One declared: "Invincible One, I entrust this enumeration of the Dharma to you, so that it may without fail come to be practiced in the future time, the final age. Invincible One, consider: if a bodhisattva were to take and hold all the Tathāgatas — arhats, perfectly and completely awakened buddhas — who presently dwell and live throughout the worlds of the ten directions, as well as all those who will practice and come to practice in the future, and all

those who have passed fully into nirvāṇa — were he to honor, revere, attend upon, and make offerings to all those Tathāgatas with every kind of provision for happiness throughout their lives, and continue to make offerings for that same duration of time even after they have passed into nirvāṇa, would that bodhisattva accumulate great merit?"

Maitreya replied: "Blessed One, upon hearing this example my mind grows bewildered — such a mass of merit would be beyond all measure."

The Blessed One declared: "Invincible One, a bodhisattva who takes up, holds, reads, masters, and extensively teaches this enumeration of the Dharma to others — and who, even if heard only briefly, generates devotion toward it — that bodhisattva will accumulate merit even far exceeding that. Invincible One, after I have passed into nirvāṇa, if a certain woman — whether she be the one called Sister who Dispels Doubt, or the bodhisattva called Dispeller of All Obscurations, or one who hears the name of the Tathāgata King of Vigorous Craving — or if anyone, upon hearing even briefly this enumeration of the Dharma, that very one will, in the body that is their last, swiftly and perfectly awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. After passing from this life, they will delight all the buddhas who appear in the world. They will entirely relinquish the eight unfree states. They will remember their former lives. They will attain dhāraṇī. They will obtain the thirty-two marks of a great being. Moreover, they will no longer dwell in a womb. Why is this so? Because those holy beings make the aspiration: 'May all women who hear our names come to be endowed with these qualities.'"

While the Blessed One, joyful, spoke these words, the bodhisattva, the great being Maitreya, together with —

gods, humans, asuras, and gandharvas rejoiced at what the Blessed One had declared.

Thus concludes the Great Vehicle sūtra called "The Deliberation of the Buddhas."

Translated and edited by the monk-translators Palyang and Paltsegs.

Translator's Notes

- The text's title in Sanskrit as given is Āryabuddhasaṃgīti-nāma-mahāyānasūtra, "The Noble Mahāyāna Sūtra Called the Assembly of Buddhas." The Tibetan title renders saṃgīti as bGro ba, which literally means "consultation, discussion, deliberation" rather than the more common rendering "assembly" or "chanting together." The translation follows the Tibetan functional

sense throughout, rendering it as "assembly" in the title and "consult, confer" in the body where the verbal usage makes the deliberative meaning clear.

The location description is unusual and geographically specific: the cave of the "lord of excellent mountains Vaideha" near the dense mango grove in the Middle Country. This does not correspond to the standard Vulture Peak setting and may indicate an alternate or symbolic location unique to this sūtra.

The name རྒྱལ་པོ་འབྲུག་གི་ཕུག་པོ་, rendered "King of Resolute Craving," is a striking epithet for a buddha. The term *sred pa* ordinarily means craving or thirst, one of the links of dependent origination. Its use as part of a buddha's name likely carries a transformed or transcended sense, but the text offers no gloss; the literal rendering is preserved.

- The cave of Indraśaila (*dbang po'i brag gi phug*) is the famous cave near Rājagṛha associated in canonical sources with the Tathāgata's meditation retreat; the name means "the cave of Indra's cliff or crag." The text's instruction for Ānanda to guard the retreat, and the Blessed One's firm refusal of any such need, is a doctrinal point emphasizing the Tathāgata's invulnerability and transcendence beyond protection — consistent with standard tathāgata-epithets in mahāyāna sūtra literature.

The Elder referred to as Maudgalyāyana (*gnas brtan maud gal gyi bu chen po*) is Mahāmaudgalyāyana, the disciple renowned above all others for supernormal powers; Ānanda's self-deprecating comparison is a well-known trope.

- The phrase rendered "make the Dharma your need" translates "*chos dgos par gyis shig*," literally "make Dharma something you need or require." This could also be read as "take Dharma as your purpose." The rendering chosen conveys the imperative sense of orienting one's life around the Dharma.

The "three gateways of liberation" are the classical triad of emptiness, signlessness, and wishlessness, which the text then elaborates individually in the lines that follow.

The phrase "patience with non-arising" renders "*mi skye ba la bzod pa*," the standard technical term for "the forbearance or acceptance of the non-arising of phenomena," a recognized stage on the bodhisattva path corresponding to the realization of emptiness. The text then adds the crucial point that one must not become conceited or self-satisfied even regarding that realization.

The passage ends mid-sentence in the source; the translation reflects this.

- The phrase rendered "enters into the inner state of correct placement" translates a somewhat compressed Tibetan expression for the Tathāgata entering meditative composure or inner absorption. The sense is that when the Buddha is in meditative equipoise and unavailable for direct address, Ānanda is to teach in his stead.

The passage's treatment of the noble truths is highly non-standard and reflects a Mahāyāna reinterpretation in which the truths are redefined in terms of non-arising, emptiness, and equanimity rather than in their classical Abhidharma formulations. This is consistent with the sūtra's overall Mahāyāna doctrinal orientation and should be understood in that light.

- The epithet "Kinsman of the Sun" renders རྒྱལ་པོ་འབྲུག་གི་ཕུག་པོ་, a standard epithet of the Buddha as a member of the solar lineage of the Śākyas; this is its first occurrence and a brief implicit gloss is embedded in the rendering to aid comprehension without interrupting the flow.

The passage on the aggregates with the five similes parallels Saṃyutta Nikāya 22.95 and the Prajñāpāramitā tradition; the foam simile for form, bubble for feeling, and so forth are canonical and rendered accordingly.

The text ends mid-sentence with "no sound —" as the supplied Tibetan closes at མཐུག་པོ་ without completing the enumeration; the dash signals the continuation that follows in the next passage.

- The term "dri za" (gandharva) and "mi 'am ci" (kinnara) and "lto 'phye chen po" (mahoraga) are standard members of the eight classes of non-human beings frequently listed together in sūtra literature; they are rendered by their recognized Sanskrit equivalents. The phrase "byer bur gyur" describing the garments filling Jambudvīpa is rendered "covering it densely," capturing the sense of dense, piled covering. The phrase "yang dag 'jog la bzugs" for the Tathāgata's three-month retreat is rendered "remaining inwardly in perfect meditative composure," reflecting the technical sense of placing the mind in correct, undistracted meditative abiding.
- The samādhi name rendered as "Abiding without Location, Spontaneously Present, Bearing the Character of Space, Moving without Signs" is a compound Tibetan title for a proper samādhi name; its individual elements are translated descriptively as the text presents them. The phrase "king of the desire realm" for Jutse'i Gyalpo is an epithet whose precise referent here — whether it is an epithet of the Blessed One or a name of a buddha in the field being visited — is left as the text has it; the grammar most naturally reads it as an appositive to the Blessed One, which is doctrinally unusual. Readers and scholars may wish to consult the Sanskrit or Chinese parallels.

The world-realm "Sarvaprabhāsa" (Tibetan Kun du 'od) is translated directly from the Tibetan as a proper Sanskrit reconstruction.

- The phrase rendered "The Buddha's Discussion" translates "sangs rgyas bgro ba," where "bgro ba" carries the sense of deliberation, discussion, or conferring. The term suggests buddhas conferring among themselves about the Dharma, and could also be translated "The Buddha's Deliberation" or "The Buddha's Counsel." The choice of "Discussion" is consistent with the context of teaching and expounding.

The line "mā btud pa btud pa med pa" — rendered "neither gathered nor dispersible" — is genuinely difficult. The phrase could also mean "what has not been contracted cannot be contracted" or "what has not been subdued cannot be subdued." The reading chosen fits the apophatic series in context, but some uncertainty remains about the precise force of this pair.

- The term rendered "steadiness" for རྒྱལ་མཚན་ (nan gtan) is a somewhat unusual usage. The standard Tibetan term for "concentration" or "stability" is ting nge 'dzin (samādhi), while nan gtan more commonly means "certainly" or "for certain." In this context it appears to function as a substantive meaning something like "firm abiding" or "steadiness," referring to a quality of stable dwelling in the dharmadhātu. This is a genuinely consequential interpretive choice.
- The long catalogue of faults beginning with śrāvaka-vehicle faults and continuing into bodhisattva-vehicle faults is a classic Mahāyāna rhetorical device demonstrating that even the highest spiritual aspirations, when held with a reified sense of self ("I will..."), constitute conceptual elaboration and thus obstruction. The text breaks off mid-sentence at the end of this passage; the translation faithfully reflects that open ending.
- The phrase rendered "the master of the gift is a śramaṇa" introduces a list that is cut off mid-sentence in the source passage; the continuation will complete the contrast between worldly and transcendent generosity. The term རྒྱལ་མཚན་ (śramaṇa) here begins what is likely a list of recipients or agents that distinguishes worldly generosity, and the sentence breaks off before the second item.
- The king's name "Yugasṛi" (Tibetan: རྒྱལ་མཚན་ལྷ་མོ་) is uncertain; the Tibetan literally means something like "the king of entering and craving" or may render a Sanskrit royal name. The reading here follows the Tibetan phonetically pending Sanskrit source verification.

The compound "འཕྲུལ་འཕྲུལ་འཕྲུལ་འཕྲུལ་འཕྲུལ་" could alternatively be a descriptive epithet rather than a proper name; without the Sanskrit original this cannot be resolved with certainty.

- The phrase rendered as "purification of the arising of successive buddha-fields" (འཕྲུལ་འཕྲུལ་འཕྲུལ་འཕྲུལ་འཕྲུལ་) is somewhat elliptical in the Tibetan. The compound འཕྲུལ་འཕྲུལ་ can mean "successive," "later and later," or "hereafter," and the sense is the cultivation of ever-further buddha-fields birth after birth. The same phrase recurs in the second-ground passage where it is rendered "eight qualities that arise in successive buddha-fields," following the parallel structure.

The phrase for the fifth-ground item rendered as "being tolerant toward attachment, aversion, and delusion" (འཕྲུལ་འཕྲུལ་འཕྲུལ་འཕྲུལ་འཕྲུལ་འཕྲུལ་འཕྲུལ་འཕྲུལ་) is structurally unusual in the list, as it falls among things to be abandoned. The Tibetan verb འཕྲུལ་འཕྲུལ་ means "to endure" or "to be tolerant," and in context this likely means the bodhisattva should no longer indulge or tolerate these three poisons — that is, it too belongs to the category of things to be relinquished. The rendering follows the plain sense of the Tibetan, and this grammatical tension may reflect the source text.

- The phrase འཕྲུལ་འཕྲུལ་འཕྲུལ་འཕྲུལ་འཕྲུལ་ refers to the thorough purification of the "three spheres" or "triple circle," the standard Madhyamaka notion that in any virtuous action the agent, the recipient, and the action itself are free of conceptual grasping; this is rendered "thoroughly purifying the three spheres of action" to make the doctrinal sense clear to a general listener. The term འཕྲུལ་འཕྲུལ་ is rendered "gandharvas," celestial musicians, a standard member of the eight classes of non-human beings. The passage ends mid-sentence in the source, and the translation reflects this as a natural continuation point.

- The passage is a well-known arapacana syllabary, the series of letters whose gateways into the nature of phenomena form a standard teaching in Mahāyāna literature, particularly the Prajñāpāramitā and Avataṃsaka traditions. The Tibetan transliterates the Sanskrit syllables phonetically; the translation above preserves these as their Sanskrit letters in roman script, which is the standard scholarly convention and aids listener recognition. Slight variations in syllable order and doctrinal glosses occur across versions of this list; the rendering here follows the Tibetan text as given without harmonising it to any other canonical recension.

The phrase rendered "the tentacle of craving" translates a term literally meaning "the creeper or tendril of thirst," a standard Indic metaphor for craving's entwining grasp on existence; "tentacle" is used to convey the organic, binding imagery for a listening audience.

- The phrase rendered "the three spheres perfectly pure" refers to the standard Mahāyāna notion of the three spheres of an action being free of reification: agent, object, and action itself. The Tibetan "འཕྲུལ་འཕྲུལ་འཕྲུལ་འཕྲུལ་འཕྲུལ་འཕྲུལ་འཕྲུལ་འཕྲུལ་" is somewhat compressed; the reading adopted takes "non-arising" as the mode in which that purity is understood, consistent with Madhyamaka commentary on this formula.

The passage ends mid-sentence at "འཕྲུལ་འཕྲུལ་འཕྲུལ་" — not nihilism — indicating the text continues and this is a genuine truncation of the source passage.

- The buddha-field name rendered as "Utterly Radiant in All Directions" translates the Tibetan Kundu Öd literally. The corresponding Sanskrit name (something like Sarvatra Prabhāsa or similar) is not given in the Tibetan text and has not been supplied.

The name "King Juktsé" renders the Tibetan Jugtsé kyi Gyalpo, a phonetic rendering of what appears to be a Sanskrit epithet. The precise Sanskrit behind this epithet is not recoverable with certainty from the Tibetan alone; "Jugtiṣyarāja" is a plausible reconstruction but tentative.

The phrase rendered "patient acceptance of the unborn nature of phenomena" translates mi skye ba'i chos la bzod pa, which is the standard Tibetan for anutpattikadharmakṣānti, the

bodhisattva's patient acceptance of the fact that phenomena do not ultimately arise — a key attainment on the path.

- The phrase rendered "great elephants among men" translates the Tibetan "skyes bu glang po che de dag," a stock epithet comparing great beings to bull elephants; it is a recognized honorific used for buddhas and bodhisattvas and is preserved in its literal force here.

The final line breaks off mid-sentence in the source, as this is a continuous passage; the translation faithfully reflects that point of interruption. The next speaker appears to shift from Maitreya back to an unnamed voice addressing both Mañjuśrī and Maitreya, which will be clarified by what follows in the next passage.

- The Tibetan phrase "dmigs pa chen po" rendered throughout as "great object of focus" carries a technical nuance: it can mean a heightened or exaggerated focus, and in the closing lines the Tathāgata's thought seems to use it in a slightly ironic or critical sense regarding Mañjuśrī's grand motivation, contrasted with the "strong sense of self" (bdag tu 'dzin pa che ba). This ironic valence has been preserved by faithful literal rendering.

The bodhisattva name "Heap of Confidence" renders "spobs pa'i phung po" — the same term rendered "eloquence" or "confidence" in the preceding passage, maintaining consistency.

The passage breaks off mid-sentence in the source, consistent with it being a continuation passage.

- The phrase rendered "great elephants of that kind" reflects the Tibetan glang po che chen po de 'dra ba dag, which uses the image of great elephants as a simile for the majestic presence of the assembled beings. The exact referent is slightly elliptical in the Tibetan, but the sense is that the assembly was as magnificent and imposing as a gathering of great elephants.

The repeated term rendered "display of miraculous power" translates rdzu 'phrul mngon par 'du bya ba mngon par 'dus byas pa, a technical phrase meaning something like "having fully assembled and brought forth the manifestation of miraculous capacity." The rendering is deliberately kept readable for a listening audience while preserving the sense of intentional, deliberate deployment of supernatural ability.

- The passage plays repeatedly on the word "abiding" (gnas pa) as both a technical meditative term — the establishment of mindfulness (dran pa nye bar gzhag pa, skt. smṛtyupasthāna) — and an ordinary sense of physical location, and this wordplay drives the dialogue. The rendering attempts to preserve this deliberate ambiguity throughout.

The phrase rendered "all ordinary persons — being like children — are made to wander through attachment, aversion, and delusion" is a pointed inversion: Mañjuśrī says he himself has "risen" from precisely the ordinary, affliction-driven abiding of childlike beings. This is a rhetorical paradox characteristic of the text's Mahāyāna dialectic.

- The passage contains a chain of synonyms where "ultimate limit," "limit of sentient beings," "limit of self," "limit of saṃsāra," and "space" are presented as equivalent expressions. This is a characteristic Mañjuśrī-sūtra rhetorical device in which each term is dissolved into the next until all resolve into the ineffable openness of space. The rendering "ultimate limit" for yang dag pa'i mtha' follows the standard Madhyamaka usage where koṭi in the sense of bhūtakoti means the real or absolute limit, i.e., the ultimate endpoint of reality.

The phrase "knowing has not arisen" renders rig pa ma skyes, where rig pa here likely stands for Sanskrit vidyā in the sense of a liberating or luminous knowing, as the counterpart to ma rig pa (ignorance, avidyā). The chain is structured as a reversal of dependent origination: no going entails no seeing of ignorance, no arising of knowing, and so on. The doctrinal point is subtle: the text is not saying that wisdom fails to arise, but that in the absence of the distorted movement that is saṃsāric "going," even the conventional arising of an opposed "knowing"

does not occur, because the entire dependent chain has been dissolved.

- The term rendered "acceptance of the unborn nature of phenomena" is *anutpattikadharmakṣānti*, a key Mahāyāna technical term signifying the bodhisattva's patient acceptance or direct realization that phenomena do not ultimately arise. It is one of the highest attainments on the bodhisattva path.

The name *Raśmīrājadhvaḥ* (Tib. 'od zer gyi rgyal mtshan) means "Banner of the King of Light Rays"; it is rendered by its Sanskrit reconstruction throughout for consistency with proper-name convention.

The phrase rendered "one born of semen, offspring" translates two terms in a list of conventional designations for the person or living being found across early Buddhist texts, paralleling the Sanskrit list: *jīva*, *jantu*, *poṣa*, *pudgala*, *mānava*, and so forth. The precise Sanskrit equivalents of each Tibetan term in this list are not always fixed, but the doctrinal point — that ordinary persons "attain" these fictional designations while the noble ones attain nothing — is clear and standard.

- The phrase rendered "King *Praveśarāja*" represents the Tibetan name རྒྱལ་པོ་འཛིན་པའི་རྒྱལ་པོ་, meaning literally "King of Entering-and-Grasping" or "King of Entry and Desire." This appears to be a proper name of a buddha in a distant buddha-field, preserved here as a transliteration of a likely Sanskrit original.

The passage about "emerging from the midst of great elephants" is an idiomatic expression comparing Mañjuśrī's going beyond a large assembly or situation to an elephant leaving a herd; the doctrinal import is his surpassing of the teachings or assembly just described.

The final sentences, concerning the sister who dispels doubt and Mañjuśrī's wish not to be expelled from teachings, are syntactically compressed and contextually dependent on what precedes. The present rendering follows the most natural reading, but the referent of "this sister who dispels doubt" is uncertain; it may refer to a specific figure or to a personified quality introduced earlier in the sūtra.

- The epithet "King of Unimpeded Movement" renders རྒྱལ་པོ་འཛིན་པའི་རྒྱལ་པོ་, which is not a standard formula. རྒྱལ་པོ་འཛིན་པའི་ means something like "entering and flowing" or "penetrating and permeating." In context it functions as a buddha-epithet. The rendering offered is interpretive; the Tibetan may reflect a Sanskrit epithet not yet identified with certainty.

- The Tibetan epithet "རྒྱལ་པོ་འཛིན་པའི་རྒྱལ་པོ་" literally means "King of Conquest over Craving" or "King Who Has Overcome Thirst/Craving" — a title for the Buddha. The rendering chosen preserves both elements without pedantry. Some editors read this as a proper name rather than a descriptive epithet; the translation treats it consistently as an epithet in line with the preceding passage.

The phrase rendered "wounded" and "wound" throughout translates རྒྱལ་པོ་འཛིན་པའི་, literally "to deal a wound / to wound," used as a metaphor for a sharp, pointed question or verbal challenge that one is expected to answer. This rhetorical idiom is preserved in the translation.

- The term rendered "gandharva" translates *dri za*, literally "fragrance-eater," a class of celestial musicians in the Indian cosmological hierarchy. The term "mi ma yin pa" rendered "non-humans" is a broad category covering various spirit-beings not elsewhere enumerated.

The closing sentence "ming de yang gsob bo" is rendered "even that name is empty," where *gsob* has the sense of being hollow, nominal, or merely conventional — a strong Madhyamaka resonance signaling that even the conventional designation lacks ultimate referent.

- The epithet of the Tathāgata addressed here, rendered as "the King Who Delights in Engagement," translates the Tibetan རྒྱལ་པོ་འཛིན་པའི་རྒྱལ་པོ་. The Sanskrit original is uncertain; *saṃgaḥ* ("engagement-craving" or "delight in involvement") is an unusual

compound, and this rendering represents a plausible reading. The identity of this buddha-figure within the sūtra's narrative frame may warrant further investigation by specialists.

- The epithet of the Tathāgata in the world-realm Universally Radiant is rendered "the King Who Enters into Craving" following the Tibetan རྒྱལ་ལོ་ལྷན་པོའི་རྒྱལ་པོ།. This is an unusual and doctrinally striking epithet; the Tibetan appears to be a rendering of a Sanskrit name such as Tṛṣṇāpravavararāja or similar, and the apparent paradox of a buddha bearing a name related to craving is likely intentional and narratively significant. No emendation has been made.

The phrase rendered "without physically touching her with his two hands, yet through his blessing taking hold of her two hands" reflects a deliberate paradox in the Tibetan: he does not touch her with his hands and yet through blessing grasps her two hands. This is not a textual inconsistency but an intentional description of a non-physical, miraculous mode of contact.

- The name རྒྱལ་ལོ་ལྷན་པོའི་རྒྱལ་པོ།, rendered "King Praveśarāja," is a Tibetan translation of a Sanskrit name meaning "King of Entry-and-Craving" or more likely a proper epithet; the Sanskrit original would likely be something like Pravṛttirāja or a related form. The exact Sanskrit behind this Tibetan epithet is not determinable from the Tibetan alone, and the reading "Praveśarāja" is an approximation. A genuinely uncertain point.

The phrase རྒྱལ་ལོ་ལྷན་པོའི་རྒྱལ་པོ། ("that is impossible," literally "there is no basis for it") is a formulaic expression of impossibility; the rendering is idiomatic and accurate to the doctrinal intent.

- The name Sarvanivaraṇaviṣkambhin means "He Who Dispels All Obscurations" and is the Sanskrit reconstruction of the Tibetan byang chub sems dpa' sgrib pa thams cad rnam par sel ba, here consistently rendered by its Sanskrit name throughout. The Tathāgata's name "He Who Proclaims the Sound of the Mass of the Lion, the Goose, and the Bull-Elephant" is a direct rendering of seng ge dang ngang pa dang bal glang gi phung po'i sgra bsgrags pa; the compound is unusual but rendered faithfully. The passage ends mid-sentence, as in the Tibetan, anticipating the next section.

- The Tibetan name rendered throughout as "Roar of Lions, Swans, and Wild Oxen" is རྒྱལ་ལོ་ལྷན་པོའི་རྒྱལ་པོ།, literally "He Who Proclaimed the Sound of the Mass of Lions, Swans, and Wild Oxen." This rendering keeps the name as a recognizable epithet while remaining natural in spoken English.

The phrase རྒྱལ་ལོ་ལྷན་པོའི་རྒྱལ་པོ། (literally "wool-ox" or "yak") is rendered "wild ox" to reflect the common identification of this animal in Buddhist cosmological literature; it may also refer to a bull-elephant in some contexts, but "wild ox" is consistent with the preceding passage's established rendering.

The samādhi name རྒྱལ་ལོ་ལྷན་པོའི་རྒྱལ་པོ། ("Tormenting All Bodies") is a literal rendering of the Tibetan; the precise Sanskrit correlate is not established from this passage alone, so no reconstruction is offered.

- The phrase rendered "ten trillion aeons" translates bskal pa bye ba khrag khriḡ, literally "aeons of ten million times ten million," a standard Tibetan hyperbolic number compound. The exact arithmetic is conventional rather than precise.

The expression "the excellence of his training in heightened intention" renders lhag pa'i bsam pa'i sbyang pa'i khyad par, a technical phrase pointing to the superior aspiration and mental cultivation that enabled Mañjuśrī's swift accomplishment.

- The sister's name appears earlier in the text as Vimatīsaṃprasupta, rendered here consistent with the preceding context. The Tibetan here gives རྒྱལ་ལོ་ལྷན་པོའི་རྒྱལ་པོ།, literally "the sister who dispels doubt," which may be an alternate epithet or a gloss; it is translated here with the name used in context, following likely continuity with the established character.

The passage ends mid-sentence in the Tibetan as supplied; the translation faithfully breaks at the same point.

The phrase 我力不能及, literally "I am unable to catch the collar" or "I have no grip on the collar," is an idiom for lacking the power or means to accomplish something; it is rendered contextually as "I have no power."

- The phrase rendered "empty of inherent existence" for "ཀློང་སྤོང་གི་རྒྱུ་བྱེད་མེད་པ་ལས་སྤོང་བའི་སྐད་ཅིག་ཏུ་བྲིས་པ།" could also be rendered "naturally empty" or "empty by intrinsic nature." The reading chosen reflects the Madhyamaka doctrinal context in which the term operates throughout this dialogue.
- The passage asks Mañjuśrī about "the five eyes," a standard Buddhist enumeration: the physical eye, the divine eye, the wisdom eye, the Dharma eye, and the buddha eye. This phrase is left as rendered, since it is a transparent technical term in context.

The phrase rendered "the absolute limit" translates the Tibetan term for the ultimate boundary or limit of reality, a synonym for emptiness or suchness in Madhyamaka usage.

- The passage contains a deliberately paradoxical exchange about the five acts of immediate karmic consequence (the ānantaryas): the sister says one goes forth and takes ordination in order to "complete" them. This is an intentional reversal of conventional Vinaya logic used to illustrate the non-conceptual nature of monastic practice — a well-attested rhetorical device in this genre of Vimalakīrti-style dialogue sūtras. The reading is doctrinal, not an error.

The name rendered "King Priyamkara" translates the Tibetan རྒྱལ་པོ་ལྷ་མོ་ལྷོ་མོ་ལྷོ་མོ་, literally "King of Priya-sṛd" or "King Who Arouses Delight." No Sanskrit equivalent could be confirmed with certainty; Priyamkara is the most plausible reconstruction.

- The phrase rendered "ninety-nine times one hundred thousand tens of millions of one hundred thousand times one hundred thousand immeasurable eons" reflects the Tibetan numerical idiom *bya ba khrag khrig brgya phrag stong gi phrag dgu bcu rtsa dgu*, a standard hyperbolic formula for an astronomically vast span of time built from multiples of the Sanskrit terms *koṭi* and *niyuta*. The rendering is necessarily approximate; Tibetan Buddhist texts vary in how they parse such stacked numerical terms.

The epithet rendered "Free from Sound" for the wheel-turning king translates *sgra dang bral ba*, literally "devoid of sound." This may correspond to a Sanskrit name such as *Aśabda* or *Niśabda*; no firm Sanskrit attestation has been identified for this passage.

- The phrase rendered "patient acceptance of the truth that phenomena do not arise" translates the standard Mahāyāna technical term for the realization that all phenomena are without inherent origination, often given in Sanskrit as anutpattikadharmakṣānti. The Tibetan mi skye ba'i chos la bzod pa is its standard equivalent.

The figure "ninety-two billion" renders *khraḡ khriḡ phraḡ dḡu bḡu rṡa gnyis*, literally "ninety-two units of a *khraḡ khriḡ*." A *khraḡ khriḡ* is a standard large numerical unit in classical Tibetan Buddhist cosmological texts, conventionally equivalent to ten million, making the total nine hundred and twenty million; however, in some Tibetan reckonings it equals one hundred million, yielding nine trillion two hundred billion. The rendering "ninety-two billion" follows the most common scholarly convention of ten million per *khraḡ khriḡ*, treating each unit as ten million and the total as nine hundred and twenty million, but the exact figure depends on the recension and reckoning system used and is genuinely uncertain.

- The epithet "Ma pham pa" rendered throughout as "Invincible One" is the Tibetan equivalent of Sanskrit Ajita, a well-known epithet of Maitreya meaning "unconquered" or "invincible." It is used consistently here as a direct address.

The phrase rendered "Sister who Dispels Doubt" and "Dispeller of All Obscurations" refers to two named female figures or bodhisattvas mentioned by their Tibetan epithets. The Tathāgata

called "King of Vigorous Craving" is a buddha-name. These are proper names embedded in what appears to be a list of merit-generating objects of devotion for women; the passage is slightly compressed in structure and the exact referents of the three names may vary across recensions.

The final sentence is left deliberately open-ended as the Tibetan breaks off mid-sentence, indicating that the passage continues beyond what was provided.

- The final colophon names two of the well-known Tibetan imperial-period translators (lotsāwas), Palyang (dPal dbyangs) and Paltsegs (dPal brtsegs), who worked at Samye and are associated with a large body of canonical translations. No substantive doctrinal uncertainties arise in this closing passage.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.